

Power Play: Elite Networks and Authoritarian Leadership Challenges

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Abstract

Under what conditions do challengers consolidate power and when do they fail? I propose a network theory of authoritarian leadership challenges where leaders recruit their personal contacts, and identify two complementary commitment problems. The post-challenge commitment problem occurs because coalition members may be ambitious; it is ameliorated when the challenger is a bridge between otherwise disconnected groups, because these coalitions are unlikely to mobilize against them. However, serving as a bridge exacerbates the pre-challenge commitment problem: expecting to be secure after seizing power, a bridge elite cannot credibly commit to not challenging. Thus, bridge elites are more likely to consolidate power post-challenge, but are more likely to be preemptively purged by the incumbent. I test the theorized mechanisms using network data covering Nigeria’s 1983 and 1985 military coups, and show that network structure explains these coup leaders’ divergent regime consolidation outcomes including leadership tenure and institutional coup-proofing.

1 Introduction

In early 1985, Major-General Ibrahim Babangida distributed the 1978 political thriller *Power Play* to a coalition of Nigerian officers (Omoigui 2007c; Ashaka 2018). In the film, Colonel Narriman deposes a repressive civilian dictatorship only to be arrested and executed by his co-conspirator, Colonel Zeller. Echoing the film, Babangida led his coalition to depose Major-General Muhammadu Buhari, only 20 months after they had placed him into power (Siollun 2025, 62). Naming himself president, Babangida reminded his conspirators: “congratulations, we made it but remember one thing, just like we took up guns and toppled a government, we also have to watch because somebody would one day want to topple us [...]” (Siollun 2025, 83).

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Babangida’s coup demonstrates a stark reality: Dictators must systematically eliminate threats to their rule because they can never be certain that other elites lack power ambitions. This imperative is particularly acute for challenge entry dictators, who take power by mobilizing elites to depose an incumbent leader.¹ By joining a leadership challenge, elites gain rare experience forcefully deposing a leader and are often elevated in rank (Goldring and Matthews 2023a, 1920). Successful challenges also bolster coalition members’ belief that future challenges will succeed, increasing the probability that coalition members join future challenges (Singh 2014). Indeed, challenges initiated by high ranking regime insiders succeed nearly 70% of the time (Peyton et al. 2026). This vulnerability leads to the following research question: under what conditions do challenge entry dictators consolidate power and when do they fail?

To answer this question, I theorize leadership challenges from a network perspective. In the theory, challengers leverage their personal contacts to recruit a coalition strong enough to depose the incumbent. They face complementary pre- and post-challenge commitment problems, both of which arise because some elites have hidden dictatorial ambitions. The *post-challenge commitment problem* concerns a prospective challengers’ security after taking power: because they may be ambitious, coalition members cannot credibly commit to not deposing their leader in the future. To overcome this problem, the challenger must mobilize a coalition of elites that is unlikely to mobilize without the challenger’s participation. A prospective challenger only expects to be secure when they are a “bridge” between members of their coalition, because coalitions can only be recruited through the network. However, bridge elites’ higher expected security in office exacerbates their *pre-challenge commitment problem* vis-a-vis the dictator. Expecting greater security as dictators, bridge elites cannot credibly commit to not challenging the incumbent. Thus, the dictator has an incentive to purge bridge elites in case they have power ambitions, while unambitious bridge elites may lead a challenge to preempt a purge. The theory implies that bridge elites are more likely to consolidate power after a leadership challenge, but also that these elites are more likely to be purged.

I test the theory’s predictions by collecting an original network dataset of Nigerian military elites, which I leverage in a process tracing study of two military coups in Nigeria in 1983 and 1985. I argue that the military head of state after the 1983 coup, Muhammadu Buhari, was incapable of securing his regime because his coup coalition was capable of mobilizing without his participation. Less than two years later, Ibrahim Babangida deposed Buhari. In contrast to Buhari, Babangida was a bridge node in the Nigerian military elite network. As a result, his coalition could not mobilize against him and he quickly consolidated power. Close temporal proximity between the two coups holds slow-moving temporal confounders constant across the two cases.

I contribute to several important literatures on autocratic politics. As I argue, challenge entry

1. I use the term “leadership challenge” to describe irregular replacement of leaders via threatened or actual use of force (Jost and Mattingly 2025). When referring to leadership challenges by military officers, I use the more specific term coup.

dictators that “bridge” multiple groups of elites should be more likely to consolidate power because they are unlikely to be deposed by their own coalition, a highly threatening set of actors. As such, I contribute novel hypotheses to the core literature on autocratic leadership survival and consolidation (Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003; Bueno de Mesquita and Smith 2017; Svobik 2012; Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2018; Sudduth and Bell 2018; Gandhi and Sumner 2020). Furthermore, bridge elites’ greater initial security should allow them to implement more coup-proofing measures, a contribution to the literature on coup-proofing strategies (Sudduth 2017a, 2017b; De Bruin 2021; Kyzym 2025). Finally, my theory suggests that autocrats should manage their elite networks to suppress bridge elites, with implications for studies of cadre rotation, promotion, and elite repression (Woldense 2018; Bokobza et al. 2022; Goldring and Matthews 2023a, 2023b; Jost and Mattingly 2025; Saijo 2025).

2 Literature Review

Irregular leader removals are essential to our understanding of autocratic politics: they are dictators’ modal non-constitutional exit pathway, and are also the key mechanism by which elites enforce power sharing agreements with the dictator (Svobik 2009, 478; Gandhi and Sumner 2020). While some scholarship considers how a leader’s entry mode predicts their mode of exit (Sudduth and Bell 2018) or how challenge entry dictators have an incentive to purge members of their coalition (Goldring and Matthews 2023a), less attention has been paid to why some challenge entry dictators are more vulnerable to their coalition than others.

We should expect that challenge entry dictators are particularly vulnerable to their coalition. Successful challenges give coalition members practice in the art of removing an incumbent by force. For instance, Singh (2014)’s study of military coups in Ghana documents how officers strategically manipulate public information to create the impression that coups are *faits accomplis*. At the same time, coalition members demonstrate that they are untrustworthy precisely because they are willing to depose an incumbent (Goldring and Matthews 2023a, 1915). Finally, coalition members are often elevated to greater positions of power that may increase their ability to launch subsequent challenges (Goldring and Matthews 2023a, 1920).

Although existing scholarship documents many ways that a dictator can mitigate challenge risk, these strategies are likely to be less effective against challenge entry dictators’ own coalitions. For instance, cadre rotation works by preventing the formation of groups that can challenge the dictator (Woldense 2018). While crucial in the long run, this strategy is less effective against a challenge entry dictator’s own coalition because their relationships predate the regime. Alternatively, dictators may use strategies such as counter-balancing and purges. Dictators counter-balance by creating additional paramilitary organizations that incentivize officers to resist coup attempts (De Bruin 2018). By contrast, purges

work by removing threatening rivals and disrupting their ability to mobilize (Sudduth 2017b; Goldring and Matthews 2023b; Saijo 2025). In principle, both strategies can be used against a challenge entry dictator’s coalition. However, both face a fundamental limitation: if a dictator’s risk of irregular removal is already high, coup-proofing risks triggering a leadership challenge (Sudduth 2017b).

This dilemma means that counterbalancing and purges are most likely when coup risk is temporarily low (Sudduth 2017a, 2017b). Here, scholars argue that taking power via a challenge temporarily decreases elites’ willingness to rebel because a large number of elites demonstrated that they were willing to use force to install the challenger (Sudduth 2017b, 1779). Counterbalancing and purges increase following failed coups for similar reasons (Kyzym 2025; Bokobza et al. 2022). However, this signalling mechanism is less likely to discourage challenges from within the coalition because coalition members are more likely to have private information about one another’s support for their leader. Thus, while challenge entry dictators face a temporary decrease in challenge risk from elites in general, the same cannot be expected for threats from the challenge coalition. In sum, challenge entry dictators’ ability to consolidate their regime should depend heavily on their coalition’s initial ability to remove them.

3 Theory

I theorize an elite’s decision to lead a challenge as shaped by two considerations: the risk of targeted purges under the current dictator, and their expected security as dictator. Thus, leadership challenges have two stages: the mobilization stage and the post-challenge stage. In the mobilization stage, challengers must recruit powerful elites without exposing the plot to the incumbent. To do so, challengers mobilize elites that are in their network of personal contacts. The mobilization stage is analogous to Singh’s (2014, 79–80) conspiracy phase, or Jost and Mattingly’s (2025, 3) civil-military coordination problem.²

However, mobilization is only half of the story. Expected post-challenge security should also influence an elite’s decision to take power. From any elite’s perspective, challenging is preferable only if they expect to be secure in office. At its core, the problem is that dictators and prospective challengers are always uncertain about whether other elites harbour dictatorial ambitions. For instance, Paraguay’s dictator Alfredo Stroessner was deposed by Andrés Rodríguez, an ally who played a key role in the coup that installed Stroessner 35 years earlier. Similarly, Nicolas Grunitzky became Togo’s second President in 1963 after a coup organized by Gnassingbé Eyadéma. Four years later, Eyadéma deposed Grunitzky, who fled into exile. Loyalty can never be taken for granted because ambitious elites always have an

2. I use the term mobilization to distinguish this phase from Singh’s (2014) execution phase, where he theorizes coups as a formal coordination game where manipulation of public information is key to coup success. By contrast, mobilizing conspirators in the lead up to a challenge requires that elites make choices about joining or opposing coups under a near total dearth of public information. As I argue below, elites use their network of personal contacts to screen potential co-conspirators and use leverage to induce cooperation precisely because there is no public information to inform elites’ choice to join or resist a challenge.

incentive to misrepresent their true preferences; they cannot credibly commit to remaining loyal in the future.

Elite network structure is the solution to this commitment problem: because mobilizing a challenge requires that elites leverage their personal contacts, network structure influences whether elites can depose the dictator, and by extension, whether a challenger can be deposed after taking power. A prospective challenger cannot know whether members of their coalition have their own dictatorial ambitions, but they can assess whether their coalition will be capable of mobilizing against them. As I argue, challengers expect to be more secure in office when they are a unique bridge between two or more otherwise disconnected groups of elites in the network, because this means that there are few alternative pathways through which the coalition can mobilize. Bridge elites can mobilize what I term a “unique coalition:” a coalition that is unlikely to mobilize without their participation. Because a unique coalition lacks alternative pathways to mobilize against their leader, they can credibly commit to remaining loyal in the future. For the same reason, challengers with a unique coalition can credibly commit to not purging their coalition members because these purges are not security enhancing.

Crucially, the very fact that bridge elites have credible commitment with their unique coalition exacerbates their pre-challenge commitment problem with the incumbent dictator. Like all elites, bridge elites cannot credibly signal their lack of ambition. Unlike other elites, however, they expect to be more secure after taking power. For this reason, bridge elites cannot credibly commit to not challenging the dictator. It follows that the dictator cannot credibly commit to not purging bridge elites. Thus, regardless of their true ambitions, bridge elites are likely to be purged. They may decide to depose the incumbent not out of ambition, but to preempt a purge.

3.1 Setup

I assume that dictators seek to remain in office and are only removed from power when a challenger mobilizes a coalition against them. However, because dictators cannot rule alone, there are elites that control resources in society (troops, state owned and private enterprises, etc). All elites have a strict preference to be an elite rather than be excluded, while some prefer to be the dictator rather than an elite. That is, most elites are a satisfied type, meaning that they are indifferent to being a dictator rather than an elite. By contrast, ambitious types prefer to be the dictator rather than an elite. Crucially, elites’ types are unobservable. Thus, neither the dictator nor elites know with certainty whether other elites are satisfied or ambitious. Furthermore, elites are uncertain about whether the dictator thinks that they are satisfied or ambitious.

Challengers depose the dictator by mobilizing elites through their network contacts; they succeed when they recruit some proportion of the total elite population, denoted by τ^* . To prevent this, the dictator can purge elites. However, purges are not guaranteed to succeed before a challenge occurs. If

the challenge succeeds, the incumbent is removed, and the challenger becomes the dictator. If a purge succeeds, the target elite is removed and the dictator remains in power.

3.2 Coalition Mobilization

I start from the premise that elites join challenges primarily to obtain rewards and avoid punishment. They are not primarily motivated by loyalty or trust because, in the last instance, they prefer to be on the winning side of a challenge.³ Nonetheless, network connections are necessary for coalition recruitment because the challenger and recruits must choose who to cooperate with and how to induce participation *ex ante*, before an open challenge generates public information about the two side's relative chances of success. In a word, challengers and recruits must be *legible* to one another, where legibility means that elite A has private information about elite B's capabilities and idiosyncratic preferences. This private information makes it possible to choose who to cooperate with and increases the likelihood that recruitment efforts are successful. Legibility is gained through significant personal histories of direct interaction.

Legibility makes recruitment possible by two mechanisms: screening and leverage. Screening facilitates recruitment because the challenger must choose who to recruit knowing that some elites are incompetent, while others are more likely to defect to the incumbent. Additionally, the challenger can use information gained through prior interaction to infer whether an elite is willing and competent enough to depose the incumbent. By contrast, leverage operates through persuasion, where the challenger uses their knowledge of an elite's idiosyncratic preferences by offering them a tailored package of rewards (or punishments) conditional on (non-) cooperation. Put differently, legibility with an elite gives the challenger knowledge of which selective rewards and punishments will induce cooperation.

From the perspective of a potential recruit, screening and leverage mitigate two risks: entrapment and bluffs. Entrapment is a risk precisely because of the low trust autocratic environment, where elites may attempt to eliminate one another by informing the dictator of a possible challenge. Entrapment was exactly what Lt-Colonel Ibrahim Babangida first feared when Lt-Colonel Shehu Yar'Adua first broached the topic of ousting Nigeria's Yakubu Gowon in 1975 (Agbese 2012, 109). When a challenger is legible to an elite, that elite can screen genuine recruitment efforts from disingenuous recruitment. From the recruit's perspective, leverage allows the elite to estimate whether promises or threats made by the challenger are within the challenger's expected capabilities. For example, does the challenger have other contacts that are more likely choices for the lucrative appointment? Similarly, has the challenger

3. In rationalist terms, loyalty can be understood as a strategy where repeated exchange increases the certainty of payoffs for cooperating with one actor over another (see e.g. Shih 2008, 52; Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003, 66). There are two limitations to rationalist loyalty specifically in the context of authoritarian leadership challenges. Incumbent dictators often purge members of their ruling coalition or lose power suddenly, meaning that long term inclusion in the incumbent dictator's winning coalition is not guaranteed; this weakens loyalty towards the incumbent. At the same time, backing the losing side of a leadership challenge almost guarantees that an elite is purged. Hence, challengers can recruit seemingly loyal elites by convincing them that their challenge is most likely to succeed.

previously demonstrated a willingness to follow through on threats?

To summarize, screening allows elites to choose who to cooperate with, while leverage gives elites the ability to make offers that are appropriate and believable for the other elite. Legibility is required for both screening and leverage. As a result, legibility within a pair of elites is a necessary but not sufficient condition for coalition recruitment. An elite joins the challenge with some probability *iff* they are connected to the challenge leader (they are mutually legible). In the toy examples below (Figures 1 and 2), I assume that connected elites always join a challenge to simplify the theory's illustration. In practice, however, connections far from guarantee recruitment into a challenge because information gained through prior interaction allows elites to screen allies. In many cases, legibility reveals that an elite is incompetent or duplicitous. Despite this, elites should avoid initiating or cooperating with recruitment attempts when they are not mutually legible, because they have no leverage and cannot screen the other elite.

3.3 Complementary Commitment Problems

I now explain why bridge elites' network position generates credible commitment with their prospective coalitions, while exacerbating their pre-challenge commitment problem with the dictator. Recall that most elites are satisfied types, meaning that their only real preference is to avoid being purged. However, because it is always possible to be purged, ambitious type elites always have an incentive to conceal their true ambitions. Thus, any elite's promise to not challenge a dictator—either in the present period or the future—is inherently untrustworthy if that elite has the capacity to mobilize the threshold τ^* of elites. Similarly, satisfied types cannot credibly commit to not join future challenge coalitions because they primarily wish to avoid punishment by joining the winning side. For this reason, coalitions that are capable of removing their challenge leader have a post-challenge commitment problem: they cannot credibly commit to leaving the challenger in power in the future. Because coalitions are recruited through the network, credible commitment requires that the challenger has a unique coalition: a coalition that is unlikely to be mobilized without the challenger's participation.

Figure 1 illustrates why a challenger needs a unique coalition, which is only possible when the challenger is a bridge between otherwise disconnected groups in the network. As laid out above, nodes are elites and the connections between them indicate that the two elites are mutually legible, meaning that they can recruit each other into coalitions. For these simplified illustrations, I assume that $\tau^* = .5$ and that all of the challenger's connections are recruited (node position remains fixed across periods). Although the challenger in T1 has enough connections to recruit three out of five elites ($\tau = .6$), the same coalition can also be mobilized by a new challenger in the next round: the coalition is not unique.

No elite in T1 has a unique coalition. As a result, any elite that leads a challenge in T1 risks being removed in the post-challenge period. In fact, Node 1 faces both commitment problems in T2. The

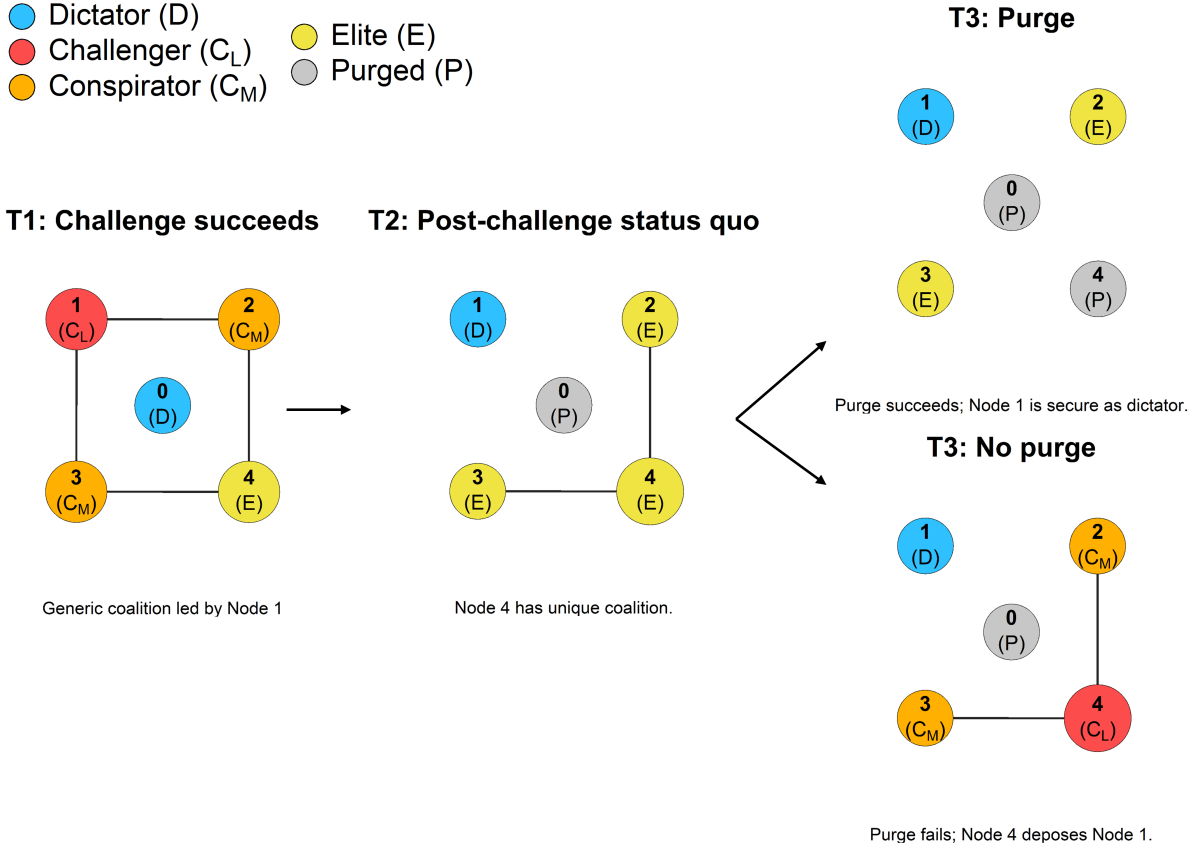


Figure 1: Node position remains fixed across periods. Nodes scaled by betweenness centrality. The incumbent's edges are removed because elites support the incumbent by default.

post-challenge commitment problem arises because they do not have a unique coalition; Node 4 can re-mobilize their coalition in T2 and cannot credibly signal that they are satisfied. Thus, Node 1 can only secure themselves by purging Node 4. However, Node 1's security is further threatened by the fact that Node 4 has a unique coalition in T2. While Node 4 cannot credibly signal a lack of ambition, they do expect to be secure after taking power. This induces the pre-challenge commitment problem because even a satisfied Node 4 prefers to challenge rather than risk being purged.

In this example, whether Node 1 (or any other elite node) should lead a challenge in T1 depends on their type and the probability that post-challenge purges succeed. If they are an ambitious type and purges have a high probability of success, they should depose Node 0 because they can most likely satisfy their ambitions by taking power and swiftly purging their (possible) rival. If purges have a low probability of success, an ambitious type elite may still prefer the status quo because the risk of taking power and failing to purge is worse than the status quo. By contrast, satisfied types are unlikely to lead a challenge in T1 even if purge success is highly probable. Satisfied types prefer the T1 status quo because purges are not security enhancing for the T1 dictator (Node 0): if Node 0 purges in T1, they induce the pre-challenge commitment problem for whichever node can still lead a challenge in T2. Hence, a satisfied type elite knows that they will not be purged given the T1 status quo and therefore has no incentive to

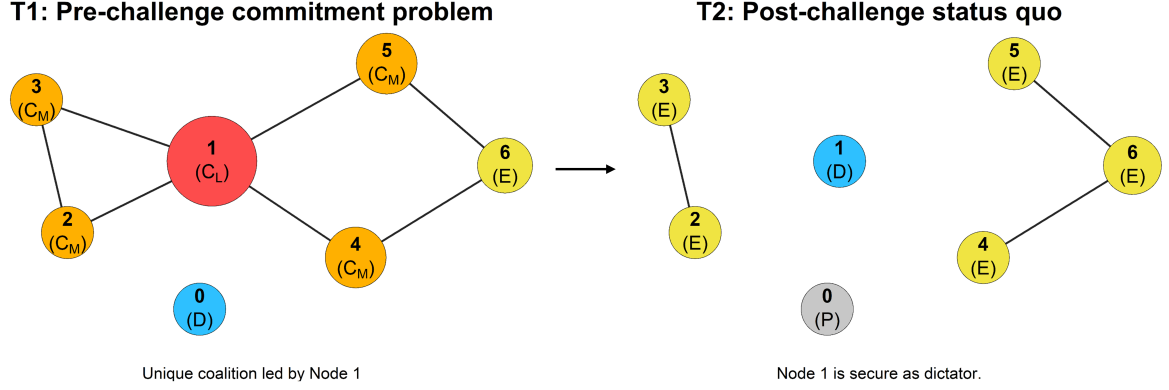
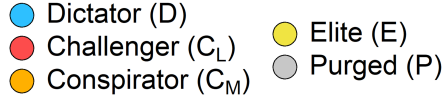


Figure 2: Node 1 has a unique coalition and therefore has a pre-challenge commitment problem. Nodes scaled by betweenness centrality. The incumbent's edges are removed because elites support the incumbent by default.

challenge.

Figure 2 shows a network configuration where the challenger has a unique coalition by virtue of their position as a bridge. In network terms, they have high betweenness centrality, meaning that they are the shortest path between a large proportion of unique pairs of nodes in the network. Nodes with high betweenness centrality are well positioned to fracture the network into disconnected groups. Once the network fractures, the remaining connected groups are too small to meet the coalition's win threshold τ^* . After a successful coup with a unique coalition, no challenger is capable of mobilizing the absolute majority required to depose the new incumbent.⁴

Thus, high betweenness centrality mitigates the post-challenge commitment problem for any prospective challenger because it prevents their coalition from mobilizing against them. For this reason, the challenger in T1 does not need to purge any elites to secure their rule. This property is unique to betweenness centrality. For instance, degree centrality captures the total quantity of an elite's connections in the network. In my theory as well as others (e.g. Jost and Mattingly 2025), degree centrality allows challengers to mobilize strong coalitions. However, a strong coalition is not necessarily unique to the challenger; strong coalitions may occur in densely connected networks with many redundant pathways between elites. Coalitions are only unique when the challenger has high betweenness.

High betweenness elites are therefore highly threatening to an incumbent dictator precisely because they have a unique coalition. Similar to Figure 1's T2 dictator, the Figure 2 dictator in T1 has a pre-

⁴. This mechanism is similar to Padgett and Ansell (1993), who argue that the Medici's betweenness centrality prevented other elite families from coordinating against them.

challenge commitment problem vis-a-vis the challenger. Because the dictator does not know whether the challenger is an ambitious or satisfied type, they have a strong incentive to preempt the threat by purging first. This in turn motivates the high betweenness elite in T1 to challenge even if they are a satisfied type. In this way, high betweenness induces the pre-commitment problem between a viable challenger and the dictator: neither can credibly commit to not striking first, because a first strike is security enhancing for both the challenger and dictator. Failing to strike first risks permanent elimination for both dictators and high betweenness elites.

4 Observable Implications

This theory produces numerous observable implications. Here I highlight three implications related to why some challenge entry leaders are more likely to consolidate their regime than others. First, challenge entry dictators with high betweenness centrality should be less likely to face subsequent challenges from the coalition that placed them into power. Instead, high betweenness challenge entry leaders face challenges from outside of their coalition or at most one subgroup of their coalition, which should be less likely to succeed. Relatedly, the second implication is that dictators should be more likely to purge high betweenness elites, particularly those that link powerful elites with a history of joining leadership challenges.

Third, high betweenness challenge entry dictators should be more able to use coup-proofing strategies such as counterbalancing or surveillance. As Sudduth (2017a) argues, coup proofing risks triggering a challenge by making future challenges less likely to succeed. A higher betweenness challenge entry dictator is relatively protected from this logic because high betweenness implies that challenges in the current period must come from a smaller or less experienced coalition that are less likely to succeed (as in the first observable implication). Additionally, coup-proofing efforts may create a perception of insecurity, for instance by making an elite suspect that the dictator is planning a purge (akin to a security dilemma, e.g.; Tang 2009). Such perceptions are particularly likely to trigger a preemptive challenge if there are other high betweenness elites in the network, because these elites have a pre-challenge commitment problem. However, challenge entry dictators with high betweenness are more protected from this threat because their betweenness mechanically implies that other elites have lower betweenness.

5 Research Design

To test the theory, I combine process-tracing with an original network dataset to compare two Nigerian coup episodes (1983, 1985) in a temporal design. The 1983 coup placed Major-General Muhammadu Buhari into office. However, he was removed in 1985 in a coup led by Major-General Ibrahim Babangida. Crucially, Babangida’s coup was executed by nearly the same coalition that placed Buhari into office 20

Table 1: Comparison of Network Metrics and Outcomes: Buhari vs. Babangida

Leader	Outcomes			
	Betweenness	Counterbalancing	Mode of exit	Tenure
Maj.-Gen. Buhari	Low	Low	Removed by own coalition	1.7 years
Maj.-Gen. Babangida	High	High	Voluntary resignation	8 years

months earlier. By contrast, Babangida was not vulnerable to his own coalition; he would step down after eight years under broad pressure to end military rule. Taken together, the two cases offer differing outcomes separated by a relatively short period of 20 months. Temporal proximity allows for a “loosely controlled” comparison between the two leaders’ coups and resulting regimes by holding slow-moving temporal confounders constant (Chyzh 2026). Table 1 compares both cases across the independent variable (betweenness centrality) and three dependent variables that capture each leaders’ consolidation of power (coup proofing, mode of exit, leadership tenure).

I pair an original network dataset of Nigerian military elites with process-tracing to demonstrate the mechanism linking each leaders’ betweenness and security (or insecurity) from removal by their own coalition. In a most similar design, process tracing leverages within-case observations to show that differences on a key independent variable are related to differences in outcomes (Bennett 2010, 208). To do this, I first show that connections observed in the data are consistent with my argument that network connections are a necessary condition for coalition recruitment (Sections 7.2 and 8.2). I then show that Buhari’s low betweenness meant that he faced the post-challenge commitment problem, meaning that his coalition was capable of mobilizing against him (Section 7.3). At the same time, Buhari’s insecurity was exacerbated by Babangida’s high betweenness centrality, which induced a pre-challenge commitment problem—Buhari and Babangida were effectively in T2 of Figure 1. Taken together, these two factors meant that Buhari’s limited coup proofing efforts were plausible triggers for Babangida’s challenge. Finally, I show that betweenness (and the resulting pre-challenge commitment problem) best explains who Babangida chose to purge, and that Babangida only began to implement his aggressive counterbalancing strategy after he had resolved remaining pre-challenge commitment problems by eliminating alternative bridge elites (Section 8.3).

5.1 Network Data

I leverage recent advances in natural language processing (NLP) to collect data on Nigerian military elite networks from 1980 to 1990. To begin, I collected a text corpus of Wikipedia articles about Nigerian military officers, identifying relevant articles iteratively through their Wikipedia categories, expanding the list of categories as new articles were identified. This process yielded 2503 unique articles that were

filtered to 1056 articles, excluding articles which did not mention Nigeria or a birth date later than 1890. Articles were cleaned and split into individual raw text paragraphs.

Using a self-hosted and version-controlled open-weights language model (Gemma4-31b), I extracted biographical data consisting of actor names, their organizational affiliations, and direct relationships with other actors. Metadata linked to organizations and direct relationships such as job titles, geographic locations, and dates were also extracted. As a final step in the NLP pipeline, I classified organizations and direct relationships using a pre-defined set of categories. Text extraction and classification performance was measured on a random sample of article chunks, the results of which are reported in Appendix E. Additionally, I validated source materials for theoretically important actors as a part of the case-study research process (see Appendix D4).

This process yielded a structured biographical dataset of 33239 rows for actor’s organizational affiliations, and 14744 for actor’s direct relationships. Actor names were linked to a canonical form using the article’s title and birth year as the master list. Biographical data that could not be linked to a Wikipedia article were dropped. Next, incomplete observations (e.g. organizational affiliations without dates) were dropped, as were organizations where actors tend to interact sporadically such as political parties, state leadership bodies (e.g. cabinets), and professional associations.

After obtaining structured biographical data, I follow prior studies of autocratic elite networks by coding connections between elites who overlap in the same organizational unit at the same time (Keller 2016; Jost and Mattingly 2025, 20–21). Although this strategy yields false-positives, it effectively captures possible pathways for coalition recruitment in the network—the core focus of my theory—while minimizing bias towards better known individuals. Additionally, I collect information about direct relationships between actors where they are mentioned in the text. For direct familial relationships, I coded connections from the beginning of the actor’s life. For relationships such as coworker, friend, or spouse, connections were coded for every year after the relationship started. All connections persist until the year that the actor dies and is removed from the network. The resulting network represents an actor’s cumulative contacts over the course of their lifetime. Excluding unconnected actors, the network includes 170 actors who were embedded in at least one military organization as of 1982 (Figure 3).

6 Network Formation in Nigeria’s Military Elite

Babangida and Buhari’s respective betweenness centralities resulted from the interaction between their career trajectories and Nigeria’s officer training program. Since 1960, officers began their training at the Nigerian Military Training College (NMTC) in cohorts of approximately 50-60 cadets (after 1964, the Nigerian Defence Academy; Agbese 2012, 42). Due to their size, NMTC training cohorts allowed cadets to develop a large number of relationships with one another. By contrast, there were relatively few

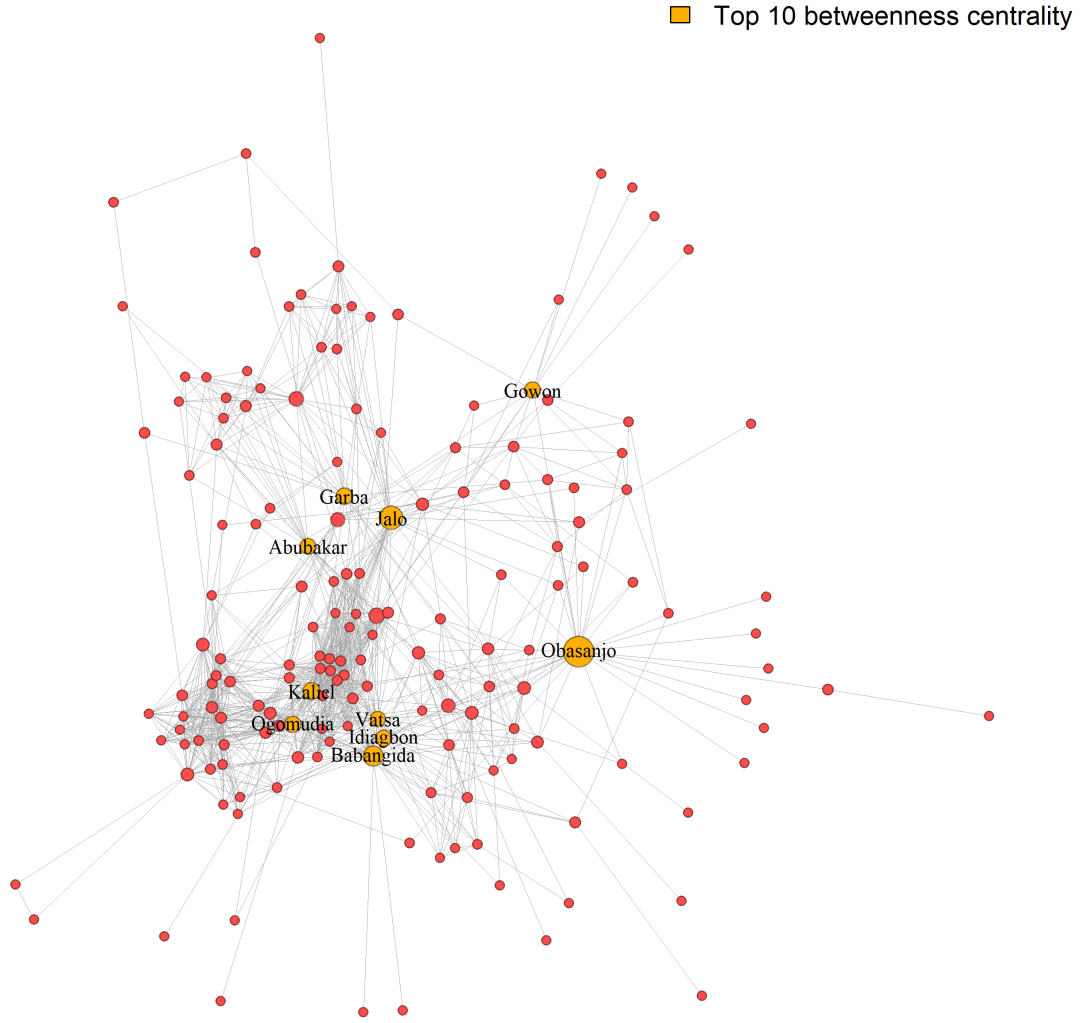


Figure 3: The military network's largest connected component in 1982. Top 10 betweenness are highlighted. Five of the top 10 betweenness actors were NDA instructors or commandants: Ibrahim Babangida, Mamman Vatsa, Gibson Jalo, Abdulsalami Abubakar, and Mohammed Kalfel. Tunde Idiagbon was not an instructor, but returned to the NDA for additional training. Finally, Yakubu Gowon and Olusegun Obasanjo were military heads of state between 1966-1975 and 1976-79 respectively.

opportunities for officers to gain connections *outside* of their NMTC cohort, because these connections primarily formed through the chain of command or idiosyncratic personal relationships. As a result, most officers had a large number of contacts within their cohort and relatively few between cohorts. Babangida was a key exception: by serving as an instructor at the Nigerian Defence Academy (NDA) from 1970-72, he gained betweenness by forming connections with many cadets. These cadets would later execute the 1983 and 1985 coups (Siollun 2025, 154). By contrast, Buhari's low betweenness was typical because he never served as an instructor.⁵

5. See Appendix C for a more detailed analysis of high betweenness officers' positions between communities.

7 The Buhari Coup (1983)

7.1 Background

Nigeria's second republic was short-lived. Although the previous military head of state had stepped down willingly, most of the army's top leadership had served in the federal military government (Siollun 2025, 9). Despite the senior officer's politicization, President Shagari considered himself safe from a military coup because most top officers shared his ethnicity or home region (Siollun 2025, 14). However, a group of officers centred on Ibrahim Babangida was plotting his removal as early as 1982 (Siollun 2025, 11). The plotters initially planned the coup for May 1983, but delayed on Obasanjo's advice (Iliffe 2011, 104). They finally struck four months into Shagari's second term (Agbese 2012, 173).

7.2 Coalition Recruitment

Recruitment for the 1983 coup began with Major Mustapha Jokolo, who claims that he approached Buhari but was rebuffed (Ashaka 2018). Jokolo's choice to approach Buhari is consistent with the theory because he was Buhari's aide-de-camp in 1975 (Siollun 2025, 66; Ashaka 2018). After being discouraged, Jokolo then approached Major Sambo Dasuki—his classmate from the NDA—and the two successfully convinced Buhari to join the plot (Siollun 2025, 66; Ashaka 2018). Crucially however, Jokolo claims to have asked Dasuki to make the initial approach to Babangida (Ashaka 2018). While Jokolo overlapped with Babangida at the NDA, Dasuki may have had more direct contact with Babangida because Dasuki's father was Babangida's godfather (Siollun 2025, 150). Thus, Dasuki may have been more legible than Jokolo to Babangida.

Consistent with the screening mechanism, there were several officers that the coup conspirators had direct personal relationships with but deliberately kept outside of the plot. Dasuki was military assistant to the Chief of Army Staff Inuwa Wushishi (who was also Domkat Bali's coursemate at the NMTC and Babangida's coursemate at Government College Bida; Siollun 2025, 16; Omoigui 2007a). Nonetheless, rather than bringing Wushishi into the plot, the coup plotters chose to divert resources to arresting him (Siollun 2025, 21). Another was Gibson Jalo, Shagari's Chief of Defence Staff (Siollun 2025, 25). Jalo was also connected to Dasuki because Jalo was deputy commandant at the NDA during Dasuki's course. Apparently, the coup plotters had good reason to believe that Jalo would oppose the coup: Jokolo describes asking why his cousin Mohammed Jega had not been brought into the plot (Ashaka 2018). His conspirators replied that Jega would inform Jalo of the plot (Ashaka 2018), clearly implying that the conspirators knew that Jalo would not join the coup.⁶ Jalo and Wushishi were both detained and retired immediately following the coup (Siollun 2025, 25).

Finally, events on the day of the coup illustrate why attempting to recruit without mutual legibility

6. Here, Jokolo is probably referring to Dasuki, but he does not specify.

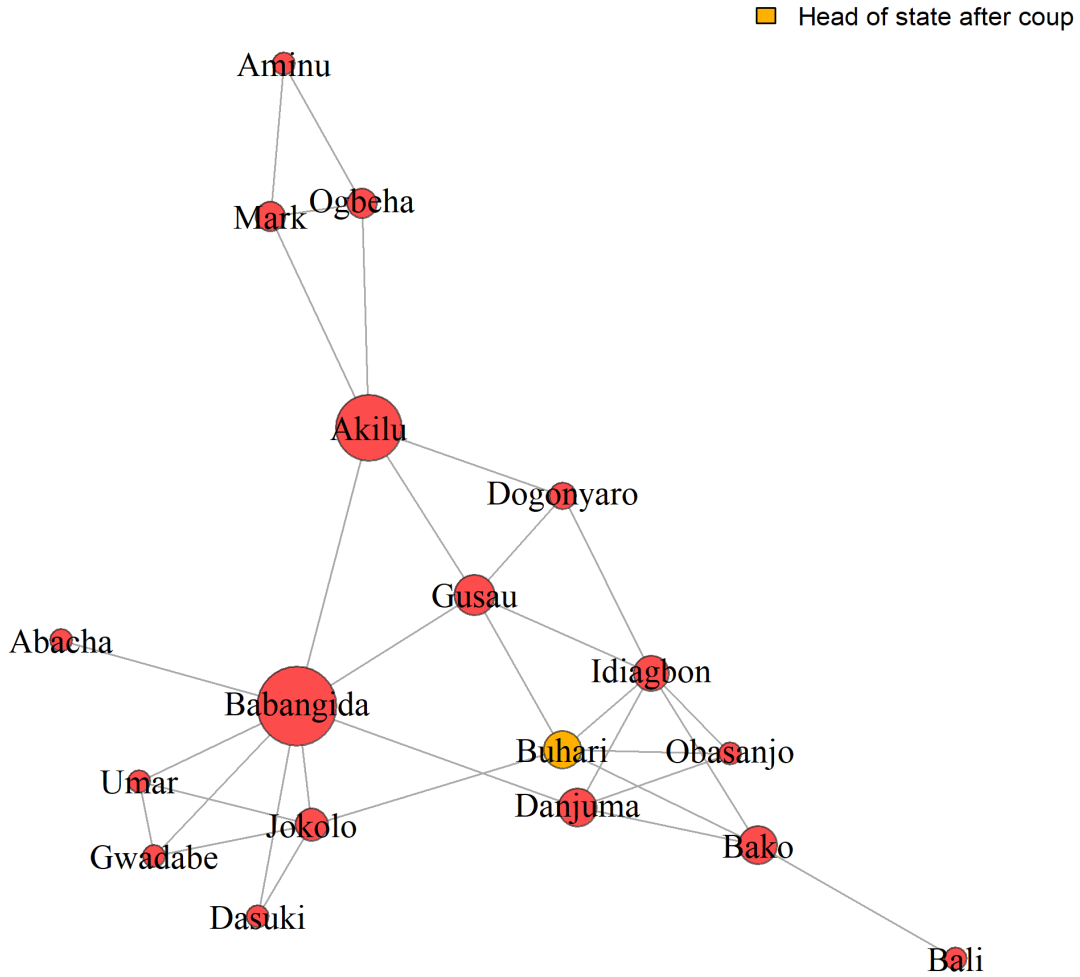


Figure 4: Active and retired officers briefed on the 1983 coup plot. Membership taken from Siollun (2025, 15–17) Node size scaled by betweenness centrality within the coalition. Although Buhari became the dictator after the coup, his coalition was not unique, meaning that his coalition could still mobilize against him.

is risky. To avoid bloodshed, the plotters wanted to arrange for Shagari’s guards to stand down. The Brigade of Guards commander was Colonel Bello Kaliel, who was Aliyu Mohammed Gusau and Joshua Dogonyaro’s NDA coursemate from 1964-1967 (Siollun 2025, 153). However, the plotters sent Lt-Colonel Tunde Ogbeha (who was commissioned in the 1967-1970 NDA cohort) to approach Kaliel rather than either of Kaliel’s classmates.⁷ Nonetheless, the choice proved inconsequential: on arriving in Abuja, Ogbeha learned that Kaliel was on leave in Lagos (Siollun 2025, 18). Unable to reach Kaliel, Ogbeha ordered the much more junior Captain Anyogo to arrest Shagari (Siollun 2025, 19; Agbese 2012, 170; Shagari 2001, 459–460). Anyogo refused, replying that he would only take orders from his own commander (Siollun 2025, 19; Shagari 2001, 460). He then warned President Shagari, and additional troops were put on alert (Siollun 2025, 19; Shagari 2001, 460). This misstep had dire consequences: Brigadier

7. It is unclear why the plotters sent Ogbeha rather than Gusau or Dogonyaro. One possibility is that the coup plotters expected Shagari to be in Lagos rather than Abuja: he was regularly flying between Lagos and Abuja at the time, and arrived in Abuja just before 4pm on December 31st. Shagari claims that his pilot had requested turning the flight back to Lagos due to poor visibility in Abuja, but landed in Abuja on Shagari’s insistence (Shagari 2001, 458).

Ibrahim Bako arrived at the State House to arrest Shagari expecting no resistance, only to be shot by loyal troops (Siollun 2025, 19).

Approaching Anyogo in this way was a mistake, because Anyogo had no way to assess *ex ante* whether the coup would succeed. Ogbeha approached Anyogo before the coup was made public; the coup plotters had not begun to “make a fact” (Singh 2014). Hence, legibility between Captain Anyogo and Ogbeha would have been key, because Anyogo needed to assess *ex ante* whether it was safer to cooperate with Ogbeha than remaining loyal to Shagari. While biographical data for Captain Anyogo are not publicly available, as a captain in 1983 he most likely graduated from the NDA after 1974. By contrast, the junior most plotters were ranked major or above and graduated from the NDA by 1974 at the latest. For this reason, it is unlikely that the coup plotters had interacted with Anyogo enough to gain legibility. Without a personal history together, Ogbeha had little leverage over Captain Anyogo, while Anyogo could not screen Ogbeha. *Ex ante*, it would have been unclear to Anyogo how likely the coup was to succeed. In this way, Anyogo’s refusal to join the plotters was consistent with the theory.

7.3 Pre- and Post-Coup Commitment Problems

Buhari was insecure after taking power. At minimum, he had low betweenness and therefore faced the post-challenge commitment problem: if members of his coalition were ambitious, he was vulnerable to removal because he lacked a unique coalition (Figure 4). At the same time, however, Babangida had high betweenness within the 1983 coalition (and the officer network as a whole) and could therefore mobilize a unique coalition (Figure 5). For this reason, Babangida had a pre-challenge commitment problem *vis-à-vis* Buhari: both could increase their security by striking first. As a result, Babangida interpreted Buhari’s limited coup-proofing efforts as threatening, which pushed him to launch the 1985 coup.

The danger that Babangida posed for Buhari was illustrated in the run-up to the 1983 coup. Babangida sought the Chief of Army Staff appointment, while Buhari preferred to give the role to Domkat Bali (Ashaka 2018; Agbese 2012, 167). According to Jokolo, Buhari’s desire to appoint Bali as Chief of Army Staff almost derailed the coup, as the plotters threatened to sabotage Buhari if he did not give the job to Babangida (Ashaka 2018). Buhari was deterred; Babangida was appointed Chief of Army Staff while Bali was given Chief of Defence Staff (Agbese 2012, 175; Siollun 2025, 26). This episode may have reinforced Buhari’s perception that Babangida posed a serious threat. Nonetheless, other accounts suggest that Buhari took the threat less seriously. Colonel Chris Alli claims to have warned Buhari and his second in command Tunde Idiagbon that there were rumours of a coup, but the two were blasé (Alli 2001, 76). Bali approached Buhari with a similar warning and also received a casual response (Ahmed 1993, 140). Buhari himself reportedly claimed that he had no intention of retiring Babangida and did not view him as a threat (Omoigui 2007c).

Nonetheless, Babangida did not share Buhari’s apparent nonchalance. The greatest contributor of

Babangida’s sense of insecurity was how Buhari appeared to be isolating his security services from Babangida. After the coup, Gusau (Director of Military Intelligence) was sent to a course in the UK. Initially, Gusau was replaced by Chris Alli—a graduate of the NDA’s first Short Service Commission in 1967 with no direct connections to Babangida (Alli 2001, 37). Alli was briefly sent abroad to connect with US Army intelligence staff, but on his return found his office occupied by Haliru Akilu (another 1983 coalition member; Alli 2001, 73–4; Omoigui 2007c).⁸ Through this maneuver, Babangida managed to keep control of the Directorate of Military Intelligence. Further, Babangida reportedly wanted Buhari to put Gusau in charge of the National Security Organization (NSO), the other security service. Buhari refused, apparently because he did not want Babangida’s allies in control of both intelligence agencies (Ashaka 2018).⁹ Instead he appointed Lawal Rafindadi, a civilian with no military background.¹⁰ Rafindadi’s appointment was one of the key events that led Babangida to view Buhari in adversarial terms. In Jokolo’s words, “Rafindadi became a problem to us because he didn’t know [any] of us and we didn’t know him” (Ashaka 2018).

Under Rafindadi, Buhari used the NSO to surveil the generals that brought him to power, particularly Babangida (Siollun 2025, 65; Omoigui 2007e). This surveillance frightened Babangida and others (Ahmed 1993, 141; Agbese 2012, 191). Believing that his home had been bugged, Babangida refused to speak candidly about the regime in his own home (Agbese 2012, 205). This intense surveillance may also explain Buhari’s failure to purge Babangida: because Babangida was watched carefully by the NSO (an independent security service), Buhari may have considered him to be neutralized as a threat.

From Babangida’s perspective, however, Buhari’s actions appeared highly threatening. At the time, there were widespread rumours that Babangida’s retirement was imminent (Agbese 2012, 189). His sense of insecurity boiled over in 1985 when Gusau—already removed from the intelligence services but still a high ranking officer—became the target of anti-corruption investigations at the ministry of defence. The investigations uncovered financial irregularities and an alleged corrupt import license scheme during the Shagari administration (Siollun 2025, 56; Agbese 2012, 189). Buhari wanted to retire Gusau over the matter, which threatened Babangida because of his close relationship with Gusau (Agbese 2012, 190; Siollun 2025, 65; Omoigui 2007c). However, Babangida was also directly threatened by the investigations (Siollun 2025, 56). Here, it is important to emphasize that the consequences for being caught up in the anti-corruption investigations were potentially severe. At the time, Buhari was pursuing a draconian anti-corruption campaign with few procedural safeguards and long minimum sentences (Siollun 2025, 34–5).¹¹ The campaign targeted civilians and military officers alike (Siollun 2025, 36). As such, Babangida could

8. Akilu and Babangida were cousins by marriage, and Akilu was frequently in Babangida’s home (Agbese 2012, 104).

9. Gusau was reportedly very close friends with Babangida (Agbese 2012, 189). However, I was unable to document how Babangida and Gusau became acquainted.

10. Rafindadi and Buhari both attended Provincial Secondary School in Katsina separated by only two years. As such, Buhari and Rafindadi most likely had overlapping networks; Rafindadi was reportedly very close to Buhari (Omoigui 2007e). By contrast, it is very unlikely that Babangida had a personal history with Rafindadi, making him an ideal candidate for NSO head if Buhari’s intention was to insulate the NSO from Babangida’s influence.

11. The minimum sentence for a corruption charge was 21 years (Siollun 2025, 35).

not take the investigation lightly.

Babangida nearly retired preemptively over the anti-corruption investigations and Gusau’s dismissal, but ultimately he changed his mind and chose to fight (Agbese 2012, 191). His former press secretary as well as Buhari himself claim that Gusau’s dismissal was a key trigger (Siollun 2025, 65; Omoigui 2007c). This is plausible, because Babangida’s coup was executed shortly after Gusau’s retirement was ordered, but before the retirement was made public; Babangida immediately reversed the order on taking power (Omoigui 2007c). At the same time, his choice to challenge Buhari rather than retire is consistent with the proposition that he understood himself as threatening to Buhari specifically because he could re-mobilize the 1983 coup coalition. As Chief of Army Staff, Babangida did not directly control any fighting units. Retiring would not immediately reduce his ability to depose Buhari because he would retain his network connections to the coup coalition, many of whom still controlled key fighting units. Thus, if Buhari wanted to eliminate Babangida as a threat, he would need to assassinate him; retirement would be insufficient to resolve the pre-challenge commitment problem.

Buhari and Babangida were in an uncomfortable position: because both faced potential elimination if the other struck first, neither could credibly commit to not removing the other (as in preventative war; Fearon 1995, 402). Moreover, it did not matter if neither actually wanted to eliminate the other. As in a security dilemma (Tang 2009), the fact that each could remove the other combined with the actions they took to secure themselves—e.g. Buhari’s surveillance of Babangida—made the other more certain that the other was planning their removal. In this way, challenge entry dictators without a unique coalition are more constrained in their ability to implement coup-proofing strategies—even in cases where elites are not interested in taking power for its own sake.

8 The Babangida Coup (1985)

8.1 Background

Babangida began planning his coup in May 1985, and the coup was executed on August 26th (Agbese 2012, 204; Siollun 2025, 61). The plot involved most of the younger officers that participated in the 1983 coup. On the day of the coup, Majors Abdulmumini Aminu, Abubakar Dangiwa Umar, Lawan Gwadabe, and Sambo Dasuki were tasked with arresting Buhari (Omoigui 2007d; Siollun 2025, 61). Buhari gave himself up without a fight, while Idiagbon (Buhari’s second in command) was out of the country (Omoigui 2007d). In the aftermath, Buhari, Idiagbon, Rafandidi, and Jokolo were retired and detained for several years.

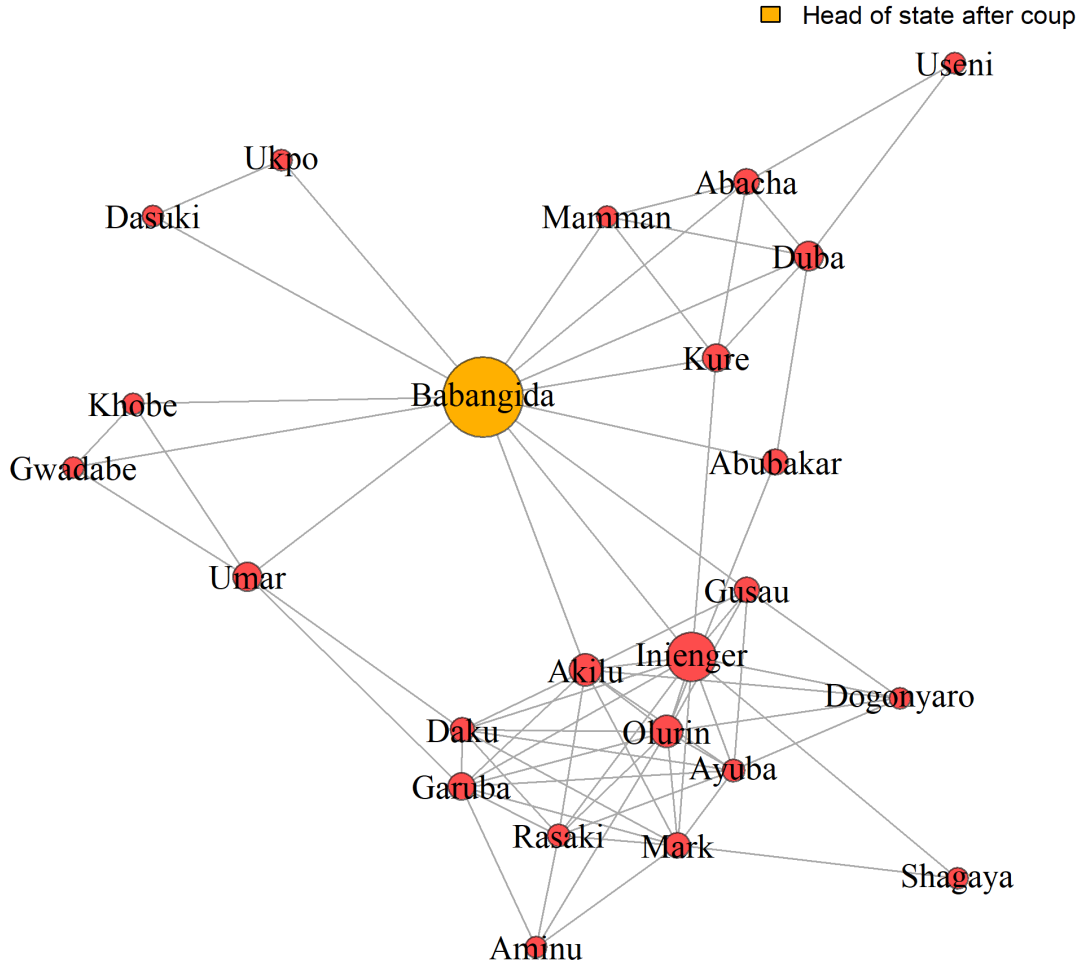


Figure 5: Active and retired officers briefed on the 1985 coup plot. Membership taken from Omoigui (2007c). Node size scaled by betweenness centrality within the coalition.

8.2 Coalition Recruitment

Recruitment efforts for Babangida’s coup are less documented compared to 1983, possibly because his regime was never overthrown. Nonetheless, a congruence of evidence supports the premise that recruitment requires legibility. One illustrative negative case comes from Minister of Defence Domkat Bali, who was recruited in 1983 but not in 1985. Bali’s exclusion was not driven by obvious animosity from Babangida, who consulted him on the 1983 coup (Siollun 2025, 17) and retained him as both Secretary of Defence and Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff until 1990 (Siollun 2025, 79, 122–3). At the same time, Bali was critical of Buhari’s draconian anti-corruption campaign (Siollun 2025, 56), so it is plausible that he would have supported Babangida’s coup if approached.

Instead, Bali’s non-recruitment is plausibly explained by a lack of mutual legibility between Bali and any member of the 1985 coup coalition. No one in Babangida’s coalition had a personal history that would create mutual legibility with Bali. By the time Babangida and others arrived at the NMTC, Bali had left to complete his training at Royal Military Academy (RMA), Sandhurst UK. Subsequently, Bali served in the artillery corps while most of Babangida’s coalition came from the armoured corps. The

only officer connecting Bako to the 1983 coalition was Ibrahim Bako, who overlapped with Bali at RMA Sandhurst. Crucially, however, Bako was killed during the 1983 coup. Other possible connections include John Shagaya and Joshua Dogonyaro, both of whom were Bali’s “Langtang kinsmen” (Siollun 2025, 58). However, both Shagaya and Dogonyaro received secondary schooling in the towns of Langtang and Gidiri respectively, each of which is approximately a 3.5 hour drive (in 2026) from Kuru, where Bali received his secondary education. As such, neither Shagaya or Dogonyaro were likely to have the personal histories of direct contact required for mutual legibility with Bali. Thus, Bako was the only network pathway through which Bali could be recruited; the exogenous event of Bako’s death led to Bali’s network isolation from the 1985 coup coalition. It is therefore consistent with the theory that he was excluded from the 1985 coup coalition.

In contrast, Brigadier Sani Abacha’s participation provides a positive example of coalition recruitment. Abacha was in control of the 2nd Division in Idaban, the closest armoured division to Lagos and therefore the officer best positioned to crush the coup (Siollun 2025, 61). However, Abacha was notoriously inscrutable (Omoigui 2007b; Siollun 2019, 37). Nonetheless, Babangida had known Abacha since their NMTC course and had the leverage to recruit him: “If it were any other person, he would have gone to the side of Buhari” (Maier 2000, 62). Crucially, Babangida’s account should not be interpreted as evidence that Abacha was loyal to Babangida: he allegedly negotiated for the highly sought Chief of Army Staff appointment (Omoigui 2007b), and later demonstrated that he was open to deposing Babangida (Alli 2001, 288).¹² Rather, Babangida’s unique ability to recruit Abacha resulted from his network position: most officers involved in the 1985 coup had no personal history with Abacha, preventing them from recruiting him for lack of legibility.

8.3 Post Coup (in) Credible Commitment

Babangida’s coalition was nearly unique: alternative pathways within the coalition were significantly less direct, making it difficult for the coalition to mobilize without Babangida. This was particularly true for Abacha, an otherwise highly threatening officer once described as a “carpetbagger” and “first tier coup merchant” (Alli 2001, 76–77). Babangida simultaneously feared and relied on him: “[Abacha] may not be bright upstairs but he knows how to overthrow governments and overpower coup plotters. He saw my coming to office in 1985 and to my protection in the many coups I faced” (Omoruyi 1999, 165; cited in Siollun 2025, 184). As such, it was particularly critical that Abacha could not be recruited by the more junior conspirators in Babangida’s coalition. Beyond Babangida’s coalition, however, there was one alternative bridge between Abacha and the junior conspirators: Mamman Vatsa.

12. Abacha took power after Babangida retired in 1993, and quickly purged many of Babangida’s allies. By 1998, Abacha was reportedly seriously considering assassinating Babangida (Maier 2000, 73). Abacha also lured Moshood Abiola (the 1993 election winner) out of exile by promising to install him into power (Siollun 2019, 46). Abiola was imprisoned by Abacha shortly after.

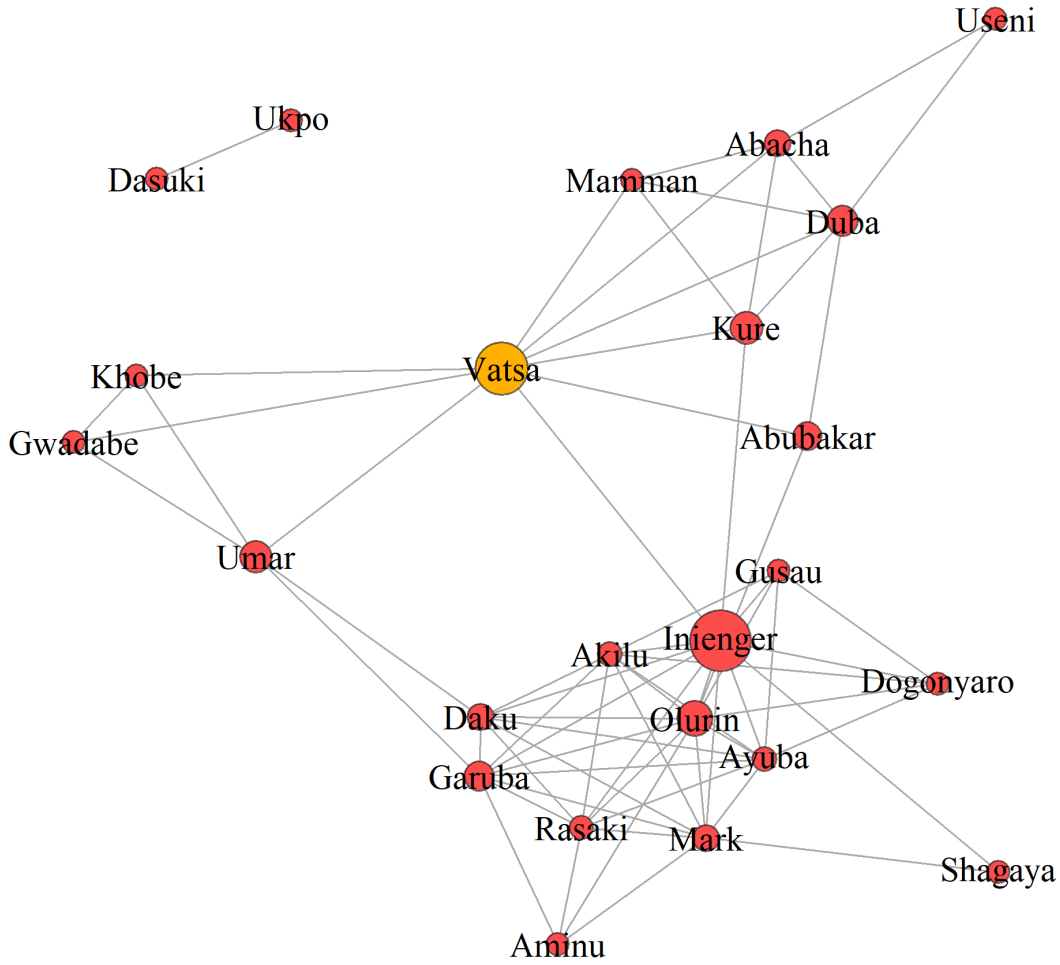


Figure 6: Mamman Vatsa's position within Babangida's coalition, where he is an alternative bridge between Abacha and junior officers such as Dangiwa Umar, Lawan Gwadabe, and John Mark Inienger. Node size scaled by betweenness centrality.

8.3.1 Commitment Problems and Childhood Friends

Vatsa was practically Babangida's network doppelganger: the two had been classmates since their youth in both Bida Middle School and the Nigerian Military Training College, and the Indian Military Academy. During the civil war, Vatsa and Babangida's units were side-by-side on the front line (Agbese 2012, 97). Finally, Vatsa was an instructor at the NDA at the exact same time as Babangida. The cumulative result was that Babangida and Vatsa's networks overlapped significantly. Figure 6 shows Vatsa's position within Babangida's coup coalition. Like Babangida, Vatsa had high betweenness; he was a bridge node between the three groups that formed Babangida's coup coalition. Thus, if any officer was capable of mobilizing the officers empowered by Babangida, it was Vatsa. As I will argue, the resulting commitment problem culminated in Vatsa's execution.

Conflict between Babangida and Vatsa surfaced shortly after Babangida took power. By December 1985, Babangida was informed of rumours of a coup plot. Many names were mentioned in the rumours, including Vatsa's (Taiwo-Obalonye 2025; Siollun 2025, 85–6; Agbese 2012, 213–14). The rumours also

mentioned Gado Nasko, another childhood friend of Babangida and Vatsa from Government College Bida; Babangida refused to believe that Nasko could be involved (Siollun 2025, 86; Agbese 2012, 214). Vatsa approached Babangida directly about the rumours, at which point Babangida insisted that he did not suspect Vatsa (Agbese 2012, 214). Nonetheless, 14 alleged coup plotters were arrested in late December, including Vatsa and his former deputy Lt-Colonel Musa Bitiyong (Siollun 2025, 89). Nasko was not arrested.

Vatsa was implicated in the plot by Michael Iyorshe's testimony, who alleged that Bitiyong was tasked with contacting Vatsa for financial support because the two were close (Siollun 2025, 92). In fact, Bitiyong did receive N10,000 from Vatsa, but Vatsa insisted that the money was given as a farming loan to Bitiyong (Siollun 2025, 93; Agbese 2012, 215). The prosecutors further asserted that Vatsa was using his authority as minister of the Federal Capital Territory to reward the conspirators with lucrative land in Abuja (Siollun 2025, 93). Babangida himself claims that he was convinced of Vatsa's guilt after he attempted to escape from his house arrest (Siollun 2025, 105; Taiwo-Obalonye 2025). Because no evidence directly implicated Vatsa, the prosecution devoted considerable effort to proving that Vatsa held personal animosity towards Babangida (Siollun 2025, 104). In the end, Vatsa and nine others were executed by firing squad (Siollun 2025, 100).

It is unclear whether Vatsa was actually involved in the plot. Although the prosecution had an informant among the conspirators (Siollun 2025, 86), none of the evidence presented indicated that Vatsa was aware of the plot.¹³ The defendants claimed that Vatsa never attended any of their meetings and the prosecution produced no evidence to the contrary (Siollun 2025, 94, 104). In fact, Vatsa's son still has a receipt for the loan issued to Bitiyong (Siollun 2025, 93), an unusual choice if Vatsa knew that the funds would be used to finance a coup plot. Regarding the land plots, Vatsa had issued occupancy permits to many members of the military government, not just the coup plotters (Siollun 2025, 104). Finally, the question of rivalry between Vatsa and Babangida is contested by those close to both officers (Agbese 2012, 217–18; 2012, 105). Domkat Bali publicly questioned whether there was sufficient evidence linking him to the plot, suspecting instead that it seemed as though Babangida and Vatsa were unable to trust one another (Wakaso 2011).

Regardless of whether Vatsa was truly involved in the conspiracy, the crucial point is that Babangida was unusually predisposed to distrust Vatsa. This is surprising, because the two had always been very close friends: they were one another's best man (Siollun 2025, 71; Wakaso 2011), and Babangida himself described how they shared shirts as roommates (Taiwo-Obalonye 2025). Babangida's wife Maryam even pleaded for him to spare Vatsa (Siollun 2025, 99). Moreover, Vatsa was one of the only senior officers with no significant history of coup plotting (Omoigui 2024).¹⁴ In fact, Vatsa had a history of opposing coups:

13. Further, it is reasonable to assume that the prosecution presented the strongest case against Vatsa, and therefore did not withhold more convincing evidence.

14. To my knowledge, Vatsa's name is not mentioned in any credible accounting of specific events from the 6 coup attempts between 1967 and 1985.

he was the first officer to publicly denounce the 1976 coup attempt against Murtala Muhammed (Agbese 2012, 138), and he was excluded from the 1983 coup coalition because he had previously served as a brigade commander in the Guards Brigade (Agbese 2012, 217). By contrast, Babangida demonstrated significantly more skepticism towards the possible implication of other officers, including those who had a history of coup intrigues. Gado Nasko was mentioned in the rumours but failed to arouse any suspicion from Babangida (Agbese 2012, 214). Similarly, Dangiwa Umar, David Mark, and Tunde Ogbeha were all questioned, but not prosecuted (Umar 2004; Siollun 2025, 89). Shehu Musa Yar'Adua—a retired officer who was part of the 1976-79 military regime—was nearly arrested when one of the coup plotters mentioned playing squash with him, but this possibility was dismissed (Siollun 2025, 90). Unlike Vatsa, none of these officers had a network position that would allow them to mobilize the three groups of officers that made up Babangida's coup coalition.

One possible explanation is that while the evidence linking Vatsa to the plot was weak, evidence linking either Nasko, Mark, Ogbeha, Umar, or Yar'Adua to the plot was nonexistent. While true, this does not explain why Babangida was threatened enough by Vatsa to execute a childhood friend. In Babangida's own words: "Despite the fact that he was my friend, playmate and course mate, he had to be executed. Vatsa was like a scorpion in one's pocket. If he had been retired he could have still planned a coup from the outside" (Siollun 2025, 105). Vatsa's network position is a strong explanation: because Vatsa could potentially mobilize members of Babangida's coalition (in particular, Abacha), Vatsa could not be trusted even in prison or exile. This is demonstrated most clearly by contrasting Babangida's treatment of Buhari to Vatsa: Buhari was released from prison after two years despite the fact that he would have held obvious resentments against Babangida for his ouster (Siollun 2025, 61–2).¹⁵ Compared to Vatsa, Buhari was weakly connected to Babangida's coalition, and his own coalition was largely retired or imprisoned. Thus, Vatsa's execution demonstrates the pre-challenge commitment problem between high betweenness elites and the dictator: because Vatsa was capable of mobilizing a unique coalition against Babangida while Babangida could not observe Vatsa's type with any certainty, Babangida found himself unable to trust Vatsa. Vatsa's network position therefore led Babangida to purge Vatsa preemptively.

8.3.2 The Quiet Kitchen Cabinet: Babangida's Credible Commitment

After purging Vatsa, Babangida's coalition had no remaining pathways through which they could mobilize. Consistent with the theory, Babangida never faced a threat from within his coalition over his

15. The difference in treatment between Vatsa and Buhari can also be explained by the fact that Buhari was ousted, while Vatsa was accused of coup plotting which had historically been punished with execution (Siollun 2025, 101). Indeed, officers from Plateau State—the home of many officers executed after the 1976 coup attempt—allegedly lobbied for the conspirators' execution (Siollun 2025, 99). Babangida himself claims that the law prevented him from sparing Vatsa (Wakaso 2011). While this would explain why the officers clearly implicated in the 1986 plot were executed, it is a poor explanation for Vatsa's execution: It seems perfectly plausible that Vatsa could have been acquitted, then retired or exiled given the lack of direct evidence linking him to the abortive conspiracy.

eight year tenure. In this section, I argue that Babangida's coalition exhibited indicators of credible commitment: because they could no longer mobilize against him, Babangida could implement more aggressive coup proofing efforts than Buhari without triggering a preemptive challenge. Likewise, when conflicts within his coalition inevitably emerged, those conflicts failed to escalate to the point of a purge or leadership challenge. Thus, while Babangida could have been deposed in a challenges from outside his coalition—indeed, he very nearly was—his coalition was itself incapable of removing him.

As argued above, Buhari's attempts to insulate the NSO from his coup coalition combined with his surveillance of key coalition members likely contributed to Babangida's decision to depose him. This did not stop Babangida from pursuing even more aggressive coup proofing reforms. Three months after eliminating Vatsa as an alternative mobilization pathway for his coalition, Babangida significantly expanded Buhari's policy of insulating the security services from his coalition without provoking a challenge. In June 1986, Babangida dissolved the National Security Organization and created three new organizations in their place: the State Security Service (domestic intelligence), the National Intelligence Agency (external intelligence), and the Defence Intelligence Agency (military intelligence; Omoigui 2007e; Siollun 2025, 151). Thus, including the Directorate of Military Intelligence under Akilu, Babangida had four independent intelligence services at his disposal. As Buhari had done, Babangida staffed many of the security services with actors that were unconnected to his coup coalition. Additionally, he created an independent national guard as well as the Security and Civil Defence Force under the Ministry of Internal Affairs (Omoigui 2007e), although these were managed by coalition members.

Of course, Buhari's appointment of Rafindadi as an independent NSO chief was only part of the trigger for Babangida's coup. Equally important was Buhari's surveillance of Babangida as well as the Gusau's dismissal. At least one unconfirmed account claims that the DMI under Akilu was carrying out surveillance of Babangida's own coup coalition (Omoigui 2007e), while Babangida's security services were apparently making officers insecure (Siollun 2025, 152). While the true extent to which Babangida was surveilling his own coalition is unknown (in part because he was never overthrown), both high- and low-surveillance against the coalition are consistent with credible commitment. If Babangida was not spying on his coalition, it would imply that Babangida was highly confident that his coalition was incapable of mobilizing against him, or that he simply trusted them not to. The former is consistent with credible commitment, while the latter seems particularly unlikely given Babangida's demonstrated preoccupation with regime security. If Babangida was spying on his own coalition, it failed to provoke a preemptive challenge. This is consistent with credible commitment: purging low betweenness elites is not security enhancing for the dictator because the purge does not remove a key mobilization pathway. As a result, coalition members would not have a strong reason to expect that targeted surveillance would lead to a purge; even if they did, they could not mobilize a strong coalition because the coalition was fractured after Babangida took power.

Consistent with credible commitment, conflicts within Babangida’s coalition never escalated to preemptive challenges or purges, even when they involved the highly threatening Sani Abacha. For example, Babangida’s junior coalition members were pushing to have Abacha removed as Chief of Army Staff and replaced with Joshua Dogonyaro (Omoigui 2007b). In reaction, Abacha accused Babangida of deliberately underfunding the army to undermine Abacha’s popularity with the troops (Omoigui 2007b). At times Abacha appeared to view himself as in competition with Babangida (Omoigui 2007b). As the Buhari episode demonstrates, these kinds of conflicts easily spiral into a preemptive coup when a high betweenness officer believes that they are likely to be purged. At other times, Abacha made choices that could have triggered a pre-emptive purge by Babangida. For instance, Abacha apparently exercised informal control of Babangida’s Brigade of Guards (Siollun 2025, 183), an action that could easily be interpreted as a sign that Abacha was planning a coup. Nonetheless, Abacha and Babangida somehow maintained their peace until Babangida stepped down in 1993.

Babangida and Abacha’s peace persisted, even once there were clear signals that Babangida was attempting reduce Abacha’s coup making ability by shifting Abacha from his coveted position as Chief of Army Staff (Omoigui 2007b).¹⁶ However, he took a delicate approach rather than moving quickly as in a preemptive purge. The plan was convoluted: In the first step, Domkat Bali’s concurrent roles were divided between Babangida and Abacha: Babangida became Minister of Defence, while Abacha served as Chairman, Joint Chiefs of Staff and Chief of Army Staff concurrently (Omoigui 2007b). The next step was delayed by a failed coup attempt that came from outside of Babangida’s coalition (the “Orkar coup”). Nonetheless, the swap was completed in September of 1990: Abacha took over as Minister of Defence, and was replaced as Chief of Army Staff by Salihu Ibrahim, an officer with no history of coup plotting (Omoigui 2007b). While delicate, Babangida’s approach nonetheless indicated credible commitment with Abacha: if Abacha was capable of mobilizing Babangida’s coalition, the rotation would give Abacha the chance to organize a preemptive coup. If a preemptive coup was the primary concern, Babangida’s optimal strategy would be to move swiftly by arresting or assassinating Abacha. At that point, however, Abacha lacked the network connections required to mobilize a strong coalition. As a result, Babangida could afford to move slowly because his coalition was incapable of mobilizing against him.

8.4 Conclusion

Why are some challenge entry dictators more or less capable of consolidating power after taking power via leadership challenge? To answer this question, I introduced a network theory of authoritarian leadership challenges. The theory predicts that a challenger’s position within the regime’s elite network makes them more or less vulnerable to subsequent challenges by their coalition. Specifically, I argued that high

16. Chief of Army Staff had been both Babangida and Abacha’s rewards for participating in the 1983 and 1985 coups (Siollun 2025, 26; Omoigui 2007b). Hence, removing Abacha from the position was a sensitive matter.

betweenness “bridge” challengers—those that connect otherwise disconnected elite groups—are more likely to consolidate power because their position between disconnected elites prevents their coalition from mobilizing in the post-challenge period. In doing so, the theory contributes individual level hypotheses to the core literature on autocratic consolidation and survival (e.g. Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003; Svobik 2012; Gandhi and Sumner 2020). Furthermore, the theory offers predictions about which elites dictators are most likely to target in purges, contributing fine grained hypotheses to the literature on elite purges as a tool for regime survival (Sudduth 2017b; Goldring and Matthews 2023b, 2023a; Saijo 2025).

I illustrated the theory’s insights by pairing a novel network dataset of Nigerian military elites with a process tracing study of two Nigerian coup episodes. While the theory’s predictions are applicable to all challenge entry dictators, future studies must evaluate whether the theory can explain events outside of the two case studies presented. The case studies also face limitations inherent to the study of opaque autocratic politics: due to limited information about key actors and events, all conclusions may be contested by newer or higher quality sources. Finally, while the temporal design holds many slow moving variables constant, there may be alternative explanations that better explain variation between and within the two case studies.

Nonetheless, my theory is consistent with variation between and within these two coup episodes. For instance, the theory explains why Muhammadu Buhari (low betweenness) was quickly removed by his own coalition while Ibrahim Babangida (high betweenness) was not. The theory also explains why Babangida managed to implement greater coup proofing reforms than Buhari: Babangida’s coalition was incapable of mobilizing against him, which meant that his coalition could not mobilize in response to the creation of isolated security services. Regarding within-case variation, the theory provides a plausible explanation for why Babangida decided to challenge Buhari, and why Babangida took the drastic measure of executing his childhood friend when only weak evidence linked him to an abortive coup conspiracy.

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Appendix A: Key Actors and Coup Coalitions

This section provides additional details about actors mentioned in the text, as well as complete lists of all officers in both the 1983 and 1985 coup coalitions. Because I am primarily interested in the recruitment process, I include all active and retired officers that are listed as having been briefed on the coup plot, regardless of whether they carried out specific duties on the day of the coup. For the 1983 coup, membership was taken from Siollun (2019, 15–17). For the 1985 coup, membership was taken from Omoigui (2007c) and supplemented with additional information from Siollun (2019, 57–66).

Tables A2 and A3 also provide each officer’s Nigerian Military Training College (NMTC) or Nigerian Defence Academy (NDA) cohorts. In some cases—particularly among officers ranked major or below—this information was not available. In these cases, I provide a best estimate for their NMTC/NDA cohort by comparing their rank at the time of the coup to other officers of similar rank. Including these imputed edges increases both Babangida and Vatsa’s betweenness centrality within the 1985 coup coalition (see Appendix B).

Table A1: Key Actors

Name	Terminal Rank	Coup Coalitions	Notes
Abacha, Sani	General	1983, 1985	Military dictator after Babangida, 1993-1998. Widely regarded as a highly capable coup plotter.
Akilu, Haliru	Brig. General	1983, 1985	Director of Military Intelligence during the Buhari regime. Akilu and Babangida’s wives are cousins.

Continued on next page

Name	Terminal Rank	Coup Coalitions	Notes
Alli, Chris	Major General		Brief head of DMI.
Aminu, Abdulmumini	Colonel	1985	
Anyogo, Augustine	Captain		Shagari's captain in the Brigade of Guards on the night of the coup.
Babangida, Ibrahim Badamasi	General	1983, 1985	
Bako, Ibrahim	Brig. General	1983	Killed in 1983 coup.
Bali, Domkat	General	1983	
Bitiyong, Musa	Lt. Colonel		Implicated in 1985 plot against Babangida.
Buhari, Muhammadu	Major General	1983	Military head of state after 1983.
Dasuki, Sambo	Colonel	1983, 1985	Babangida's godson.
Dogonyaro, Joshua	Lt. General	1985	
Gusau, Aliyu Mohammed	Lt. General	1983, 1985	Director of Military Intelligence 1979-1984.
Gwadabe, Lawan	Colonel	1983, 1985	
Ibrahim, Salihu	Lt. General		
Idiagbon, Tunde	Major General	1983	Buhari's second in command. Arrested and placed under house arrest for three years after 1985 coup.
Iyorshe, Michael	Lt. Colonel		
Jalo, Gibson	Lt. General		Shagari's Chief of Defence Staff. Former NDA (deputy) commandant from 1973-1977. Arrested and retired after 1983 coup.
Jega, Mohammed	Major General		Jokolo's cousin.
Jokolo, Mustapha	Major	1983	Buhari's aide-de-camp in 1975.
Kaliel, Mohammed Bello	Colonel		Commander of the Brigade of Guards in 1983.
Muhammed, Murtala	General		Military head of state from July 1975-February 1976. Assassinated.

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Name	Terminal Rank	Coup Coalitions	Notes
Nasko, Gado	Lt. General		Classmates with Babangida, Vatsa, and others at Government College Bida.
Obasanjo, Olusegun	General		Military head of state from 1976-1979. Voluntarily retired in 1979. Elected President from 1999-2007.
Ogbeha, Tunde	Brig. General	1983	
Rafindadi, Lawal	—		Buhari's civilian NSO head.
Shagari, Shehu	—		Civilian president from 1979-1983.
Shagaya, John Nanzip	Brig. General	1985	
Umar, Abubakar Dangiwa	Colonel	1983, 1985	
Vatsa, Mamman Jiya	Major General		Babangida's long time friend and Obasanjo's Brigade of Guards commander.
Wushishi, Inua	Lt. General		Shagari's chief of army staff 1981-1983. Arrested and retired after 1983 coup.
Yar'Adua, Shehu Musa	Major General		One of the coup conspirators responsible for deposing Yakubu Gowon in 1975. Retired in 1979.

Table A2: Complete 1983 Coup Coalition

Name	Rank (1983)	NMTC/NDA Years	Notes
Abacha, Sani	Brig. General	NMTC 1963	
Akilu, Haliru	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1967	Graduated Provincial Secondary School, Zaria in 1966. Probably NDA Short Service Course 1 or 2 because he served in Civil War immediately after graduating.
Aminu, Abdulmumini	Major	NDA 1969	NDA Short Service Course.

Continued on next page

Name	Rank (1983)	NMTC/NDA Years	Notes
Babangida, Ibrahim Badamasi	Major General	NMTC 1963	
Bako, Ibrahim	Brig. General	NMTC 1962	
Bali, Domkat	Major General	NMTC 1961	
Buhari, Muhammadu	Major General	NMTC 1962	
Dasuki, Sambo	Major	NDA 1972-74	
Dogonyaro, Joshua	Colonel	NDA 1964-1967	
Danjuma, Theophilus	Lt. General (Ret.)	Pre-NMTC	
Gusau, Aliyu Mohammed	Colonel	NDA 1964-1967	
Gwadabe, Lawan	Major	NDA 1970-72	
Idiagbon, Tunde	Brig. General	NMTC 1963	
Jokolo, Mustapha	Major	NDA 1970-72	Missing wikipedia; NDA dates confirmed from other sources.
Mark, David	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1967-70	
Obasanjo, Olusegun	General (Ret.)	Pre-NMTC	
Ogbeha, Tunde	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1967-70	
Umar, Abubakar Dangiwa	Major	NDA 1970-72	Often listed as NDA 1967-72, most likely in error: NDA courses were 3 years rather than 5. Umar describes Babangida as his instructor (indicating 1970-72), and is not included on the NDA Regular Course 3 roster (1967-70). His rank is also consistent with that of the 1970-74 officers.

Table A3: Complete 1985 Coup Coalition

Name	Rank (1985)	NMTC/NDA Years	Notes
Abacha, Sani	Major General	NMTC 1963	

Continued on next page

Name	Rank (1985)	NMTC/NDA Years	Notes
Aboho, IB	Major	Unknown	No Wikipedia or other data source; NDA 1970-74 based on rank.
Abubakar, A.	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1967	Transfer from Air Force during Civil war; NDA Short Service Course 2. Government college Bida with Babangida et. al.
Ademokhai, Peter	Brig. General	Unknown	No Iikipedia or other data source; NMTC Dec 1963 based on rank.
Ahman, Sule	Major	Unknown	NDA 1970-74 based on rank.
Akilu, Haliru	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1964-1967	
Aminu, Abdulmumini	Major	NDA 1969	NDA Short Service Course. Babangida's assistant as Chief of Army Staff.
Ayuba, Tanko	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1967	NDA Short Service Course 1.
Babangida, Ibrahim Badamasi	Major General	NMTC 1963	
Bello, UK	Major	Unknown	No Wikipedia or other data source; NDA 1970-74 based on rank.
Bulus, Kefas Happy	Major	Unknown	No Wikipedia or other data source; NDA 1970-74 based on rank.
Dada, Abubakar	Lt. Colonel	Unknown	No Wikipedia or other data source; NDA 1964-67 based on rank and NDA 3rd Regular class list.
Daku, Ahmed	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1967	Short Service Course 1 or 2.
Dasuki, Sambo	Major	NDA 1972-74	
Dogonyaro, Joshua	Colonel	NDA 1964-1967	
Duba, Garba	Brig. General	NMTC 1963	Close friends with Abacha.
Garuba, Chris Abutu	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1967-70	
Gusau, Aliyu Mohammed	Colonel	NDA 1964-1967	

Continued on next page

Name	Rank (1985)	NMTC/NDA Years	Notes
Gwadabe, Lawan	Major	NDA 1970-72	
Hart, Simon	Major	Unknown	No Wikipedia or other data source; NDA 1970-74 based on rank.
Ichide, Friday	Major	Unknown	No Wikipedia or other data source; NDA 1970-74 based on rank.
Inienger, John	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1964-67	
Khobe, Maxwell	Major	NDA 1971	Short Service Course 11.
Kure, Yohanna	Brig. General	NMTC 1963	
Madaki, John	Major	Unknown	Incomplete Wikipedia and no other data source; NDA 1970-74 based on rank.
Mamman, Abdullahi Bagudu	Brig. General	NMTC 1963	
Mark, David	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1967-70	
Mepaiyeda, S.B.	Major	Unknown	No Wikipedia or other data source; NDA 1970-74 based on rank.
Nwachukwu, Ike	Brig. General	NMTC 1963	
Olurin, Tunji	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1967-70	
Oni, Joseph Olayeni	Brig. General	Unknown	Incomplete wikipedia and no other data source; NMTC Dec 1962-3 based on rank.
Rasaki, Raji Alagbe	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1967-70	
Shagaya, John Nanzip	Lt. Colonel	NDA 1964-70	
Shehu, Musa	Major	Unknown	Incomplete Wikipedia and no other data sources; NDA 1970-74 based on rank.
Ukpo, Anthony	Colonel	NDA 1964-67	

Continued on next page

Name	Rank (1985)	NMTC/NDA Years	Notes
Umar, Abubakar Dangiwa	Major	NDA 1970-72	Often listed as NDA 1967-72, most likely in error: NDA courses were 3 years rather than 5. Umar describes Babangida as his instructor (indicating 1970-72), and is not included on the NDA Regular Course 3 roster (1967-70). His rank is also consistent with that of the 1970-74 officers.
Useni, Jeremiah	Brig. General	Unknown	Incomplete Wikipedia and no other data sources; most likely NMTC Dec 1962-3. Close friends with Abacha since mid 1960s.

Appendix B: Challenge coalitions with imputed NMTC/NDA cohorts

In this section I present network graphs for Babangida’s coup coalition where missing nodes’ NMTC/NDA cohorts are imputed based on their rank relative to officers whose cohorts are known. Because missingness primarily affected junior officers, missingness underestimates Babangida and Vatsa’s betweenness centrality. Accounting for this missingness therefore strengthens the core argument that Babangida had a unique coalition after Vatsa’s execution.

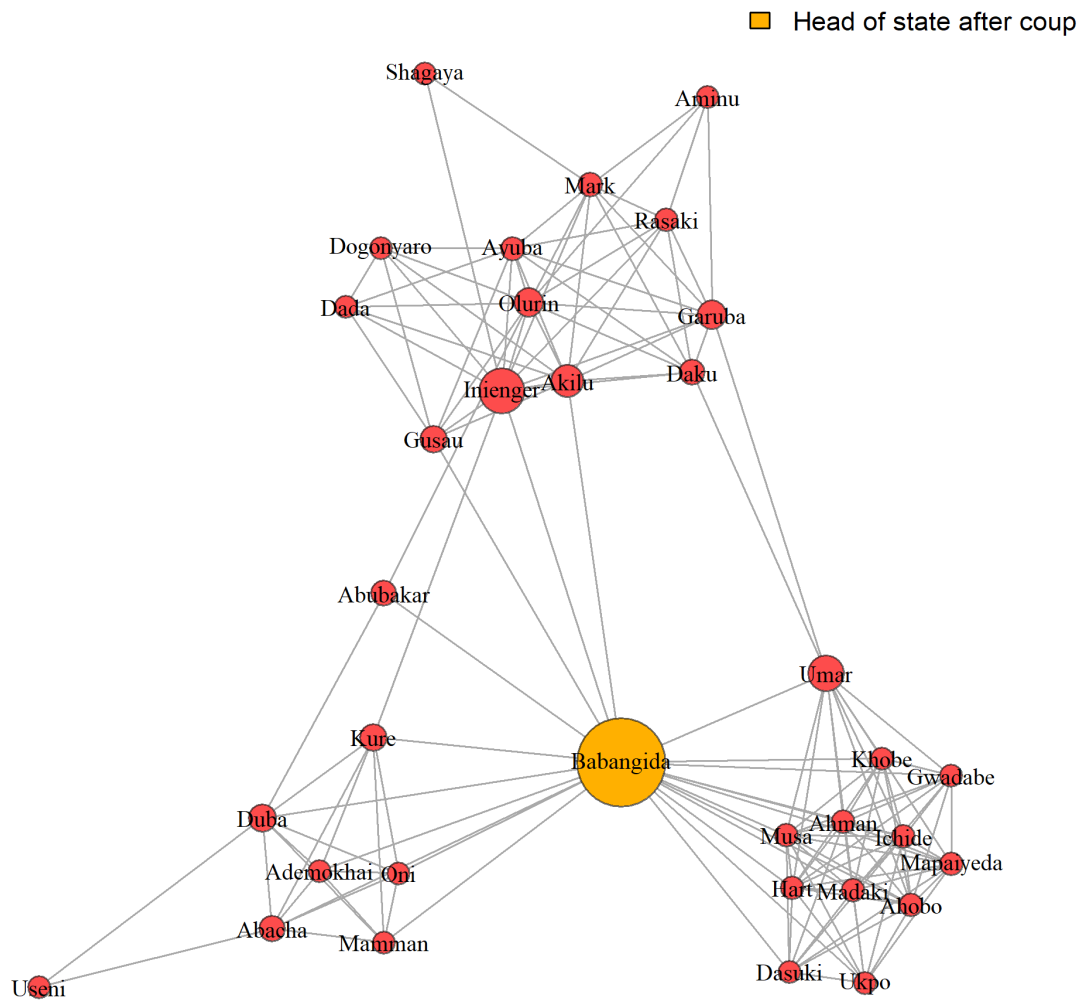


Figure B1: Active and retired officers briefed on the 1985 coup plot. Membership taken from Omoigui (2007c). Edges for missing actors imputed by officers' most likely NDA cohorts (see Appendix A1 Table A3).

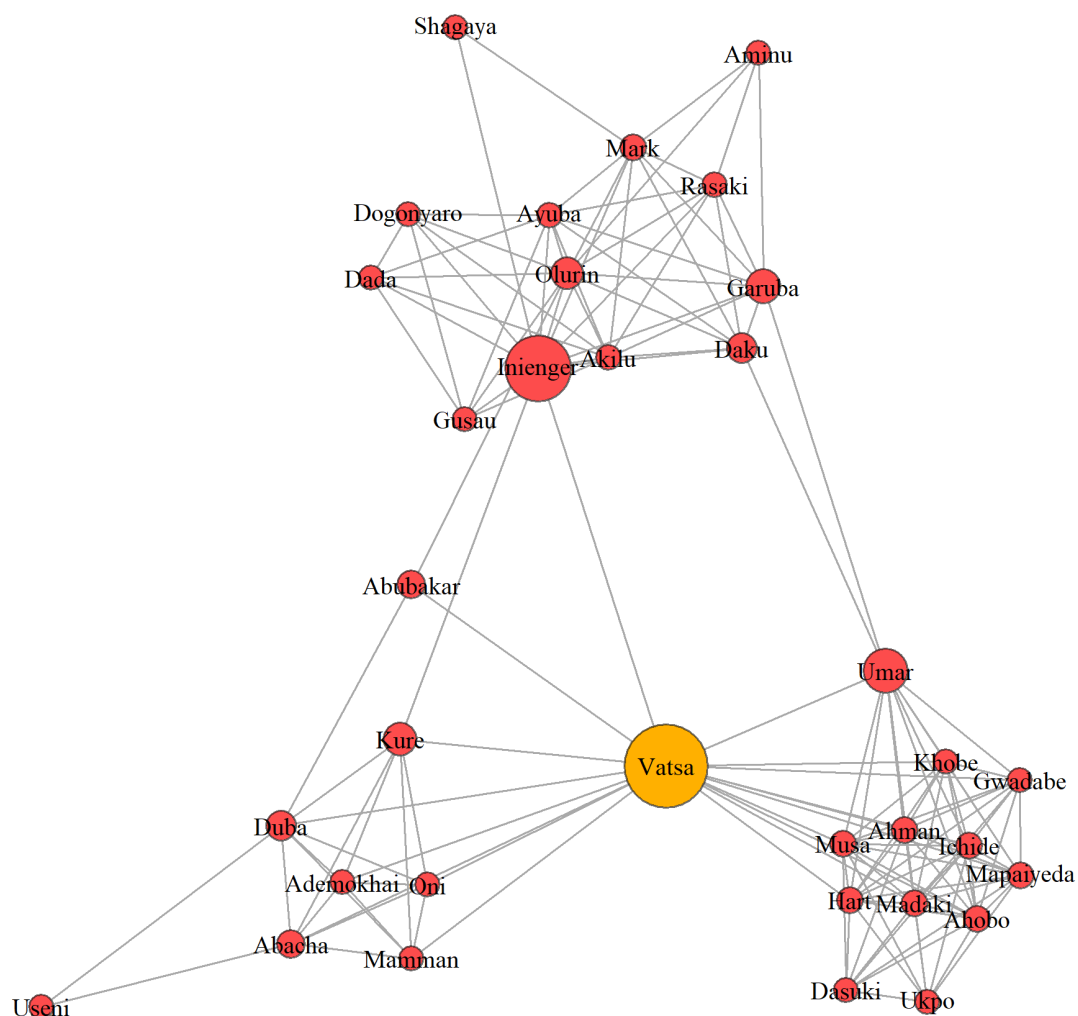


Figure B2: Mamman Vatsa's position within Babangida's coalition. Node size scaled by betweenness centrality. Edges for missing actors imputed by officers' most likely NDA cohorts (see Appendix A1 Table A3).

Appendix C: Community Detection

Babangida was particularly threatening to Muhammadu Buhari because he could assemble a unique coalition between senior and junior officers with a track record of successful coups. This was also what made Mamman Vatsa threatening to Babangida. Here I show that overall Nigerian military elite network is consistent with the argument that Babangida and Vatsa were threatening because they bridged between distinct groups of experienced coup plotters. To do so, I apply Louvain community detection to the 1982 military elite network. Community detection algorithms identify groups that are more densely connected with one another than with outsiders. Applied to the 1982 officer network, the Louvain algorithm reveals five communities that correspond approximately to different generations of Nigerian officers (Figure C3).

After the 1983 coup, three of these communities stood out for coup threat: NMTC 1960-64 (Blue), NDA 1964-70 (Yellow), and NDA 1970-74 (Purple). Babangida and Vatsa were the most important bridge nodes because they had systematic connections between the NMTC 1960-64 (as classmates) and NDA 1970-74 communities (as instructors). Both groups were essential to the 1983 and 1985 coup plot. Additionally, Vatsa and Babangida both had relationships with several members of the 1964-70 NDA cohorts through their Civil War commands and idiosyncratic family connections.

By contrast, other high betweenness nodes bridged comparatively less threatening communities. For instance, Olusegun Obasanjo—Military Head of State from 1976-1979—has high betweenness centrality, but this is because he connects NMTC era cohorts (blue) with other pre-NMTC era officers (green). Because these officers were retired by the early 1980s, Obasanjo's contacts were essentially disabled. As a result, Obasanjo was of little threat to Babangida despite his high betweenness. Similarly, Gibson Jalo (retired after the 1983 coup) served at the NDA as deputy commandant (1973-1974) and commandant (1975-1977), and retired immediately following Buhari's 1983 coup. Jalo's NDA appointments meant that he was a bridge between the 1970-74 cohorts and the 1975-1977 officers (marked in red). The 1975-1977 officers had no involvement in prior Nigerian coups, while the timing of Jalo's appointments at the NDA meant that he was only connected to the junior most coup plotter, Sambo Dasuki. As a result, Jalo was less threatening in retirement than Mamman Vatsa would have been.

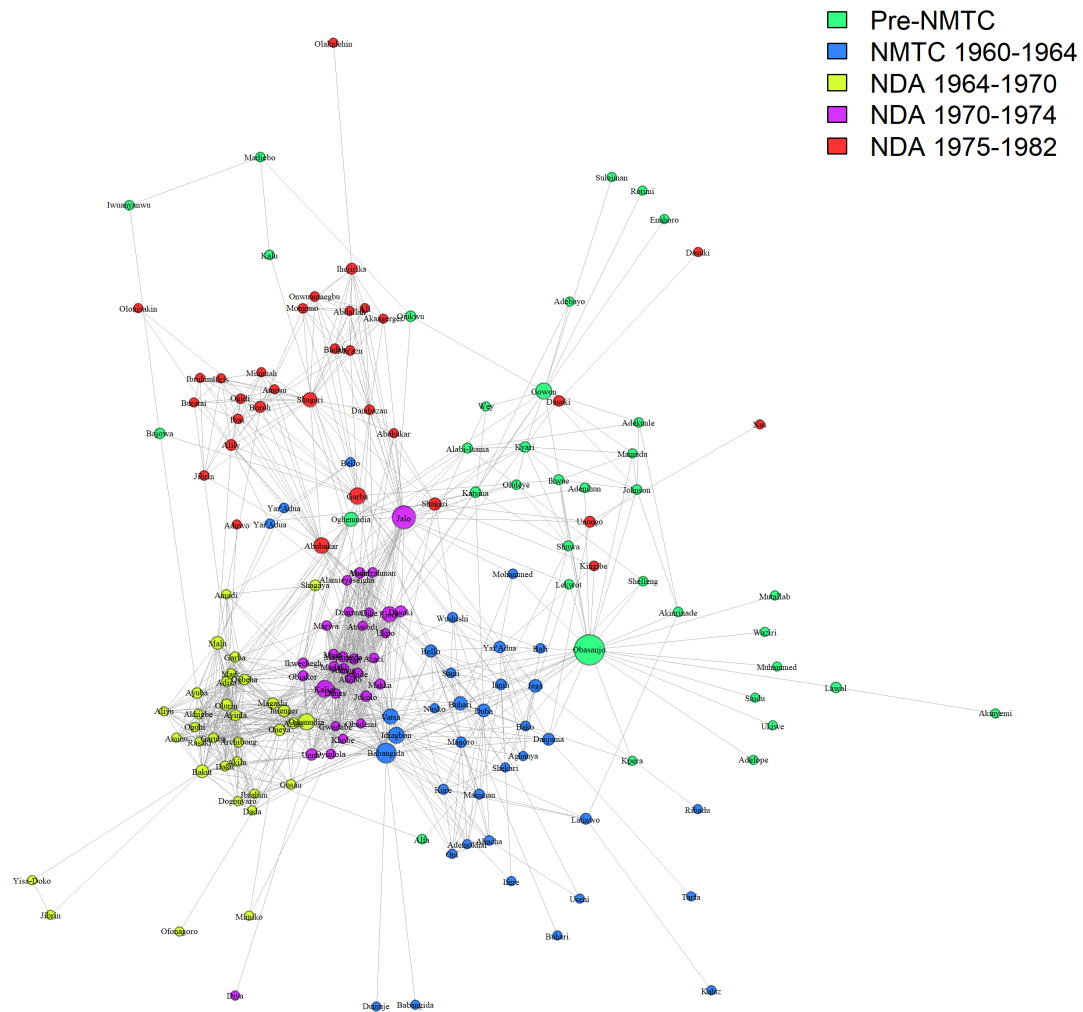


Figure C3: The military network's connected component in 1982. Nodes scaled by betweenness centrality. Communities identified using the Louvain community detection algorithm.

Appendix D: Manual corrections to biographical data

I validated the source material for coup coalition members, officers mentioned in the case studies, and high betweenness officers. Wherever possible, I triangulated correct biographical details using additional source materials including officers' memoirs, interviews, and short form CVs made available through the Nigerian Biographical and Legacy Research Foundation (Blerf.org 2026).

Table D4: Manual corrections to biographical data

Actor name	Summary of Changes
Sani Abacha	Corrected attendance dates for the NDA.
Gado Nasko	Corrected the name of NMTC.
Aliyu Mohammed Gusau	Added information about relationship direct tie with Babangida.
Anthony Ukpo	Added missing education institutions.
Yohanna Kure	Corrected birth date and added missing education institutions.
Abubakar Tanko Ayuba	Added education institutions.
Chris Abutu Garuba	Added missing education institutions.
Bagudu Mamman	Corrected name of education institution and added missing dates.
Fidelis Makka	Corrected the institution for his senior staff course.
John Mark Inienger	Corrected education dates and added his units during the Nigerian civil war.
Mohammed Kaliel	Corrected attendance dates for the NDA.
Inua Wushishi	Added missing education organizations.
Abdulumuni Aminu	Added missing education organizations and appointment as Babangida's assistant.
Tunde Ogbeha	Corrected birth date and education dates.
Mohammed Jega	Added missing education institutions, added information about direct tie with Shehu Musa Yar'Adua.
Sambo Dasuki	Added information about direct tie with Babangida.
Shehu Musa Yar'Adua	Corrected attendance dates for the NMTC.
David Mark	Added dates for education institutions.
Jeremiah Useni	Added information about friendship with Abacha.
Dangiwa Umar	Corrected NDA attendance dates.

Appendix E: Extraction performance

Extraction performance was measured on a random sample of 200 article chunks using a procedure known as pre-annotation grading (Mikulová et al. 2022; Felt et al. 2014; Lingren et al. 2014). Rather than comparing the LLM’s extractions to a human coder’s independent extractions, pre-annotation supplies the human coder with the LLM’s extractions to be graded and corrected. Thus, for each article chunk, an undergraduate RA evaluated LLM extracted data against a code book, adding missing data where necessary.

There are several reasons to prefer pre-annotation grading for the present application. Because each article chunk contains an arbitrary number and ordering of polymorphic extractions (e.g. “Nigerian Presidential Administration”, “Presidential Administration of the Federal Republic of Nigeria”), comparing model generated data to human coded data would require a fuzzy matching extractions to their corresponding human generated extraction. This matching is prone to failure, and hence risks underestimating model performance. Pre-annotation avoids this failure point. Further, the number of linked variables—nine in total—means that independent manual extraction by a human coder is error prone and should not be treated as a gold standard. Hence, it is more appropriate for the human coder to directly grade model generated extractions, which can increase annotator speed and accuracy when pre-annotations are at least moderately accurate (Felt et al. 2014; Lingren et al. 2014).

The undergraduate coder graded LLM outputs, producing three statistics: precision, recall, and another indicator for “data leakage”. Here, it is important to note that these statistics have slight differences compared to standard data annotation tasks. Decoder based LLMs are generative, meaning that they generate text unconstrained by the source text. As a result, there is an ambiguity as to whether extracted data are evaluated purely against the source text or whether the model can supplement the source text using its training data. While it is possible to grade LLM outputs solely for their conformity to the source text, this limits the usefulness of a decoder model by preventing the model from making reasonable inferences related to but beyond the source text’s literal interpretation.

Hence, in the present case, precision is interpreted as whether the model generated data are consistent with the coding criteria, which in some cases allows for extra-textual inference (for instance, inferring an organization’s region when the organization’s town is directly stated in the text). By contrast, the data leakage statistic measures whether the data are explicitly contained in the source text. Crucially, data leakage is distinct from “hallucination”, which are “overconfident, plausible falsehoods” (Kalai et al. 2025). A model may have been trained on source materials that contained the data, even if the data were not contained in the source text. In cases of data leakage, the undergraduate RA was instructed to perform a cursory internet search to validate whether the model had correctly inferred beyond the source text (e.g. “Is the Nigerian Defence Academy located in Kaduna?”), which affects precision. By distinguishing between data validity (precision) and data leakage, I am able to leverage the model’s

training data to impute certain kinds of missing data (e.g. organization locations) while constraining other data points more closely to the source text (e.g. what organizations an actor was associated with).

Table E5: Gemma4-31B-it-FP8

Variable	Precision (95% CI)	Recall (95% CI)	Leakage (95% CI)
Parent Org	0.949 (0.877, 0.98)	0.963 (0.893, 0.988)	0.022 (0.005, 0.094)
Org	0.864 (0.824, 0.897)	0.984 (0.968, 0.992)	0.004 (0.001, 0.013)
Org Class	0.998 (0.996, 1)	0.995 (0.989, 0.999)	-
Title	0.995 (0.982, 0.999)	0.799 (0.726, 0.857)	0.000 (0, 0)
Start	0.953 (0.916, 0.974)	0.991 (0.972, 0.997)	0.000 (0, 0)
End	0.973 (0.944, 0.987)	0.996 (0.971, 0.999)	0.000 (0, 0)
Country	0.998 (0.983, 1)	0.934 (0.893, 0.96)	0.000 (0, 0)
Region	0.983 (0.949, 0.994)	0.934 (0.855, 0.972)	0.161 (0.101, 0.247)
Town/City	0.994 (0.959, 0.999)	0.932 (0.865, 0.967)	0.045 (0.021, 0.093)

Note: 200 article chunks, 717 Org rows. 95% CIs clustered on the text chunk level. Organization meta-data is graded conditional on a valid organization.

Table E6: Qwen 3.5-27B-FP8

Variable	Precision (95% CI)	Recall (95% CI)	Leakage (95% CI)
Parent Org	0.815 (0.726, 0.88)	0.978 (0.931, 0.993)	0.000 (0, 0)
Org	0.848 (0.805, 0.883)	0.906 (0.87, 0.932)	0.001 (0, 0.011)
Org Class	0.941 (0.932, 1)	0.939 (0.93, 1)	-
Title	0.990 (0.966, 0.997)	0.730 (0.668, 0.784)	0.000 (0, 0)
Start	0.954 (0.914, 0.976)	0.958 (0.92, 0.978)	0.007 (0.002, 0.028)
End	0.956 (0.906, 0.98)	0.956 (0.91, 0.979)	0.005 (0.001, 0.035)
Country	1.000 (1, 1)	0.871 (0.829, 0.904)	0.000 (0, 0)
Region	0.983 (0.939, 0.995)	0.924 (0.871, 0.957)	0.185 (0.126, 0.265)
Town/City	0.981 (0.938, 0.994)	0.981 (0.951, 0.993)	0.062 (0.03, 0.124)

Note: 200 article chunks, 740 Org rows. 95% CIs clustered on the text chunk level. Organization meta-data is graded conditional on a valid organization.

Although both models leave room for improvement, overall extraction performance is highly satisfactory. The organization variable is particularly important, because organizational overlaps are the primary indicator used to code relationships between actors. Both models achieve good precision and excellent recall on organizational extractions. Additionally, data leakage is well controlled by prompt design: as instructed by the prompt (Section F), both models rarely (less than .4% of the time) generated organizations that were not directly mentioned in the source text. This ensures that primary edge coding variables closely correspond to the text corpus. By contrast, imputing missing region data is desirable as these data are rarely mentioned explicitly but can be reliably inferred. Here, models infer beyond the source text approximately 16% of the time. Nonetheless, generated region data were valid over 98% of the time.

Appendix F: Selected prompts

Organizational Extraction

Identify **all** specific organizations and associations with which <name> was directly involved, i.e., the structure in whose activities <name> was directly involved.

An organization is a stable social entity with a collective identity and, typically, a name. In addition to government, educational, and commercial structures, this includes clubs, communities, cooperatives, parties, creative unions, and other forms of association.

For each organization, also extract the specific structural divisions to which <name> belonged. These can be any internal groups: departments, faculties, branches, sections, clubs, etc. Record them in the `sub_organizations` field within the corresponding organization.

Examples:

Principle of Hierarchy and Atomicity:

- **Separation:** Never combine names of different levels into a single string. Each division must be a separate object in the `sub_organizations` array.
- **Incorrect:** `"org_name": "Physics Department, Moscow State University"`
- **Correct:** `"org_name": "MSU" → sub_organizations: [{"org_name": "Physics Department"}]`
- **Top-Down:** Start with the highest organization level.

Filling Rules:

- **Strict Filter:** Include only organizations where <name> is directly related to `org_name`.
- **Recursion:** If a division has its own departments, nest them recursively. If there are no nested departments, use `[]`.
- **Names Only:** The `org_name` field should contain only the name of the organization. Titles (e.g., "Deputy Minister") are not included in the JSON, and do not repeat the name of the parent organization.

Output Format: Return ONLY valid JSON.

```
[
  {
    "org_name": "TOP_LEVEL_ORGANIZATION",
    "sub_organizations": [
      {
```

```

        "org_name": "SEPARATE_DIVISION",
        "sub_organizations": []
    }
]
}
]
```

If the text does not specify an organization or division for <name>, return **null** in the corresponding field. If the organization's name is not clearly stated, do not attempt to guess its official name.

Be careful: only include an organization if the text clearly states that <name> was a member of it or was directly involved with it. If the text mentions other people, list **ONLY** the organizations with which <name> was directly involved.

Organization Classification

Based on the provided text, classify each organization using the following categories:

EDU: Educational institutions of all types, including universities and other post-secondary institutions.

RLG: Faith-related organizations, including religious administrative structures, religious education institutions, churches, etc.

MIL: Military units of all types.

LAW: Law enforcement agencies (e.g., the Ministry of Internal Affairs, the Prosecutor's Office).

INT: Intelligence organizations (e.g., the FSB, the KGB).

PTY: Political parties (e.g., United Russia).

GOS: The aggregate of government bodies at all levels and state institutions (from federal ministries to local services) that ensure the functioning of the state through the work of civil servants and public sector employees.

GLD: The aggregate of the highest institutions of state power at the federal and regional levels, vested with the authority to determine policy and make strategic decisions. These include the Presidential Administration, the Executive Office of the Government of the Russian Federation, federal ministries, as well as the administrations of heads of constituent entities (governors), and regional governments.

IGO: Intergovernmental Organizations (e.g., the European Union, the United Nations).

SOE: Public Sector Enterprises (PSEs) are commercial organizations in which the state holds ownership or decisive control. These include both wholly state-owned corporations and joint-stock companies with state participation (e.g., Rostec or Rosatom).

COM: Private Sector Enterprises (PSEs) are commercial organizations owned by private individuals or non-state shareholders. These include both private (closed) firms and public corporations whose shares are traded on stock exchanges (e.g., Digital Sky Technologies or Yandex).

ASS: Professional Associations or Unions (e.g., the Union of Writers, the Union of Lawyers).

ART: Organizations related to the arts, including music, theater, etc. (e.g., the Bolshoi Theater).

CIV: Civil society organizations created to achieve specific goals.

CAS: Citizens' recreational associations are voluntary, non-profit organizations (or clubs) created by individuals based on shared interests to meet needs in recreation, sports, arts, or gardening.

SPT: Sports teams, clubs, and other athletic organizations.

INF: Informal organizations, such as gangs or other groups of people (e.g., the "Cambridge Five" or "Kadyrovites").

Fill in and return only the following JSON, placing all relevant categories in the "categories" list. Do not add or rearrange the **org_name** values:

<json_here>

If the organization does not fit into any of these categories, return an empty list [].

Categories are not mutually exclusive; please select **ALL** relevant categories.

Dates

Based on the provided text, determine the earliest and latest years of <name>'s relationship with the corresponding **org_name**. Record the earliest year in the **start_year** field, and the latest year in the **end_year** field. If the text indicates that <name> left **org_name** on a specific date, record this in the **end_year** field.

Fill in and return only the following JSON, replacing **ONLY** the default value -1. Do not add or rearrange the **org_name** values:

```
<json_here>
```

If the text does not specify the earliest or latest year of <name>'s relationship with **org_name**, replace -1 with **null** for the appropriate year.

Make sure you only specify the start and end years for <name>'s relationship with **org_name**, and not years associated with another person or organization.

Direct Relationship Extraction

Identify **all** clearly specified relationships between <name> and any other person (**relation_name**) mentioned in the text. A relationship is clearly specified if the text clearly implies that <name> and **relation_name** clearly knew each other and had regular direct contact. Single events together does not imply a relationship.

Output Format: Return **ONLY** valid JSON.

```
[
  {
    "relation_name": "TARGET_PERSON_NAME", # Do not add formal titles or
      other descriptors to target_name.
  }
]
```

Be careful: only include a relationship if the text clearly states that <name> had a direct relationship with that person. If the text mentions other people, list **ONLY** the people with which <name> had a direct relationship.

Direct Relationship Classification

Based on the provided text, classify the relationship between <name> and <target_name> (**relation_name**).

Use the most appropriate label from the following list:

SUB (Subordinate): <name> reports to <target_name>. <target_name> is the boss/-manager. <name> answers to <target_name> and they have regular, sustained direct contact.

SUP (Superior): <name> is the boss/manager of <target_name>. <target_name> reports

to <name>. <name> has authority over <target_name> and they have regular, sustained direct contact.

COW (Coworkers/Classmates): <name> and <target_name> work or study together in the same formal organization for a sustained time. They are peers; neither person answers to the other.

APT (Appointment): <name> officially appointed or hired <target_name>, but they do not necessarily have regular direct contact or work together daily.

FAM (Direct Family): <name> is related to <target_name> by birth. <target_name> must be <name>'s mother, father, brother, sister, or cousin.

SPS (Spouse): <name> is married to <target_name>.

FRD (Friends): <name> and <target_name> are clearly implied to be friends.

OTH (Other): The relationship exists but is not accurately described by any of the categories above.

Guidelines:

- Labels are mutually exclusive. Fill `tie_type` with only the most relevant label.
- If you are unsure of the most relevant label based on the text, return `null`.
- Do not change the value of `relation_name`.

Fill and return ONLY the following JSON.

```
<json_here>
```

SOURCE TEXT: